Lost in Translation

15 Hebrew Words to Transform Your Christian Faith

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Preface

The Hebrew Scriptures—what Jews call the Tanakh and Christians know as the Old Testament—are more than ancient texts. They are sacred breath. These writings form the spiritual backbone of both Judaism and Christianity, anchoring our beliefs, shaping our morality, and guiding our imaginations of God.

But what happens when these sacred texts are filtered through the lens of another language, another worldview? Can the "Word of God" still speak with clarity and fire? Yes. And yet—something essential can be muted, something vital can slip between the cracks of translation. Like a masterpiece repainted in another style, the form may remain, but the texture, the intention, the spirit—can shift.

Why Hebrew Still Matters

To read the Scriptures in Hebrew is not simply to change languages. It is to step closer to the original voice. Hebrew is the mother tongue of the prophets, the poets, the psalmists, and the priests. It carries within it the soul of a people and the fingerprints of divine revelation. It is a language sculpted by covenant, exile, wonder, and hope.

Because Hebrew is not just a language. It is a worldview.

Each word in Hebrew is a window. It holds within it layers of meaning—linguistic, historical, poetic, theological. A word like *SHALOM* is not just "peace"; it is wholeness, restoration, balance, flourishing, and the felt presence of divine order. *CHESED* is not just "mercy"; it is covenantal love, stubborn kindness, relational fidelity, and undeserved grace wrapped in one syllable.

In English, we often divide these concepts into separate terms. In Hebrew, they live together—braided like threads in a tapestry. That's what makes the original language so powerful: it doesn't reduce meaning, it multiplies it.

Hebrew Wordplay

This is especially true in the poetry of the Psalms, the wisdom of Proverbs, and the narrative wordplay of Genesis. When Adam calls his companion *ISHSHAH* (woman) because she was taken from *ISH* (man), he is not just naming her—he is revealing a mystery about human unity, gender, origin, and mutual belonging. In Hebrew, wordplay isn't clever; it's sacred.

Even the name of God—*YHWH*—whispers mystery. It emerges from the verb to be, suggesting not just existence, but Being itself. Eternity. Presence. Faithfulness. When a Jew recites the *Shema* (Deuteronomy 6:4)—*"Hear O Israel, the LORD is our God, the LORD is one"*—they are not just affirming monotheism. They are proclaiming the self-existence and oneness of a God who was, who is, and who will be.

Of course, most readers of the Bible do not speak Hebrew. And that's okay. Translations have allowed the Word to go forth to the ends of the earth. But we must

not forget that **every translation is also an interpretation**. Theological choices are made. Nuance is lost. Sometimes even meaning is reshaped.

Lost in Translation

This book is not written to make anyone feel excluded from the depths of Scripture. It is an invitation. Whether you are fluent in Hebrew, just learning the aleph-bet, or simply curious—my hope is to help you hear some of the beauty that can be lost in translation.

The fifteen Hebrew words explored in the coming chapters are not technical entries in a lexicon. They are sacred echoes. Each one contains a mystery worth meditating on, a revelation worth reclaiming.

If this book awakens in you even a small hunger to know the Bible more deeply, then it has done its job. And if it brings you even one step closer to the heart of the God who spoke these words into being—that, for me, is everything.

(For further reading on how to interpret Scripture from a Hebraic perspective, you may also enjoy my companion book: ***Read Like a Jew: 8 Rules of Basic Bible Interpretation for the Christian***.)

Introduction

To read the Bible only in translation is like listening to a symphony through a wall—you may catch the melody, but you miss the depth, the texture, the trembling emotion behind each note. English translations of the Hebrew Scriptures can indeed provide life-changing insights. Yet, behind every translated word lies a fuller world—a world encoded in Hebrew, the ancient tongue through which God spoke creation into being, gave a written covenant to Israel, and whispered His promises to the prophets.

When Words Lose Their Soul

To engage with the Bible in its original Hebrew is to step through a veil—to touch the breath of the text itself, unfiltered, alive, layered with echoes of poetry, prophecy, and paradox. This is not a scholarly privilege but a spiritual gift for those willing to journey deeper into the Word that shaped worlds.

This is not to diminish the value of translations. They are bridges across time and language. But every bridge has a toll. And the price we pay in translation is the loss of poetic nuance, cultural resonance, and linguistic depth—the very elements that make the Scriptures come alive.

The Compressed Power of Biblical Hebrew

Biblical Hebrew operates like a compressed diamond—small in vocabulary, vast in depth. With just around 8,000 root words, Hebrew achieves an extraordinary feat: it says more with less. As a language soaked in symbolism, each word is a world unto itself, radiating meanings that shift with context, emotion, and spiritual insight.

But herein lies the problem. English, with its analytical precision, often demands clarity at the cost of creativity and complexity. Translators are forced to pick a single shade from a rainbow. They must decide: is this word meant to evoke mercy or covenant? Justice or wrath? Crossing a river, or crossing a line?

When they choose, something is lost. Not always wrongly, but inevitably.

The Silent Loss in Every Translation

Let's be clear: for those who cannot read Hebrew, the Scriptures are still accessible. The Word of God is not held hostage by grammar. But that does not mean translation is neutral. Every translated word is an act of interpretation. Every verse rendered in another tongue carries the fingerprints of the translator's theology, worldview, and unconscious bias.

Imagine reading poetry in a language where rhyme doesn't exist. Or watching a drama where every actor wears a mask. You may grasp the story—but the soul? That's another matter.

The Feminine Spirit and the Myth of Gender

Consider a small but revealing example. In Genesis 1:2, we read that *"the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters."* In Hebrew, the word for Spirit—*Ruach*—is grammatically feminine. This doesn't mean the Spirit is a woman, of course. Grammatical gender is not the same as personal identity. But already, we are faced with a cultural and theological dilemma.

In Greek, *pneuma* (Spirit) is neuter—genderless. In English, we usually say "He" for the Spirit, following tradition, not grammar. So, what happens to a verse as it travels from Hebrew to Greek to Latin to English? What do we gain, and what do we lose, when gendered language becomes entangled with theological assumptions?

These are not merely academic concerns. They shape how we picture God. How we pray. How we relate to the Spirit who hovered over chaos like a mother bird brooding over her nest.

The Hidden Architecture of Words

One of Hebrew's most stunning features is its root system. Unlike English, which

builds meaning through prefixes and suffixes, Hebrew begins with raw roots—three consonants that act like DNA strands from which whole families of meaning are born.

Take the root **A.V.R** — **A**[yin]-**V**[av]-**R**[esh] — which is the root of the word *Hebrew* (IVRIT):

Avar means to pass over or through.

[A]ivri means a Hebrew person—but also the one who crossed over.

Ma'avar refers to a crossing or passage.

Averah refers to transgression—crossing a moral boundary.

In another context, it also means wrath or judgment.

One Hebrew root (A-V-R). Multiple meanings. All orbiting the shared theme of movement, boundary, transition. This is the genius of Hebrew: being highly symbolic, it connects moral, historical, and physical ideas through one spiritual thread. And this is precisely what is lost when we tear a word from its root and drop it into English as a single, fixed meaning.

The Untranslatable Beauty of Wordplay and Idiom

The Hebrew Scriptures are full of idioms, poetic devices, wordplays, symbols, allegories, and metaphors that shimmer with meaning—but only in their native soil. When uprooted and replanted in another language, many wither.

English readers may never know that a Hebrew word in one verse is echoed in another, or that a prophet is making a pun with a place name, or that a Psalmist is drawing from agricultural imagery that no longer resonates with modern ears.

Without Hebrew, we miss the joke. We miss the poetry. We miss the heartbreak behind certain laments or the irony behind certain prophecies.

When Theology Becomes a Matter of Vocabulary

The deeper danger of translation is not simply misunderstanding a word—it's misunderstanding God. This happens subtly, over time, and usually with good intentions. But it happens. Always.

Every translator makes decisions: Is God passive or active in this verse? Does He permit evil, or cause it? Is a command conditional or eternal? Is grace limited or abundant? These are not just linguistic questions. They are theological convictions wrapped in grammar.

And when these choices are repeated across generations of Bibles, sermons, and doctrines, the words take on a life of their own. In time, they begin to shape entire belief systems—often without the reader even realizing it.

In the United States, for instance, most Bible translations have been produced by Protestant scholars—and as a theologian, I can clearly see the influence of Protestant theology embedded in the way certain passages are translated. Let me share an example…

One Word, Two Theologies

Take, for example, a line from Matthew 10:29.

The 1611 Anglican KJV emphasizes God's awareness of all that happens, stating:

> *Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father.*

Now compare that to the popular modern Protestant translation—NKJV—which adds a word not found in the original Greek:

> *Are not two sparrows sold for a copper coin? And not one of them falls to the ground apart from your Father's* ***will****.*

The first rendering speaks of God's intimate awareness. He knows everything — even when a hair falls of your head (Matthew 10:30). The second implies divine causality—that not even a sparrow can die unless God ***wills*** it. The Greek text does not include the word "will." It was added by translators, likely of the Calvinist tradition. But this small addition leads to a monumental shift: from a God who witnesses suffering, to a God who ordains it.

This is not a question of grammar. It is a question of who we believe God is.

The Role and Risk of Interpretation

Translation is never a neutral act. It is always interpretation. And interpretation is always influenced by culture, theology, assumptions, and even fears.

The original languages of Scripture—Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek—are rich in ambiguity, symbolism, and poetic density. They invite contemplation, mystery, tension. But modern translations often prefer clarity, certainty, and Systematic Theology. In doing so, they may resolve tensions the Bible never intended to resolve. They may flatten parables, idioms, and poetry into doctrine, and metaphor into mechanism. Worse, they may inject man-made doctrine right into your Bible.

This is not an attack on translators. It is a call to awareness. To humility. To deeper study. And to reverence for the original Word.

Bridging the Gap Without Drowning in It

Yes, Hebrew is difficult. Yes, it's ancient and complex and sometimes frustrating. But it is also an open invitation. You do not need to become a scholar to begin tasting the depth of its wisdom. You simply need curiosity, reverence, and the willingness to slow down.

Even comparing different translations side by side can awaken new insights. Consulting someone familiar with Hebrew—ideally, someone who speaks it fluently, not just someone who took a class in seminary—can unlock a world of meaning. The point is not to become a linguistic purist. The point is to listen more carefully. To hear what was really said—not just what we've been told it means.

The Purpose of This Book

This book is not a dictionary. It's not an academic textbook or a technical grammar manual. It's a spiritual excavation.

Each of the fifteen Hebrew words you'll encounter in these pages is a doorway—a sacred threshold. Not into abstract knowledge, but into transformed vision. These words are not just theological terms; they are living concepts that can change the way we think, pray, forgive, suffer, and love.

Some are familiar, others you may have never heard. But each carries a unique spiritual voltage. Each one invites you to return—to the original voice, the original intention, the original beauty. To read not just with your eyes, but with your soul.

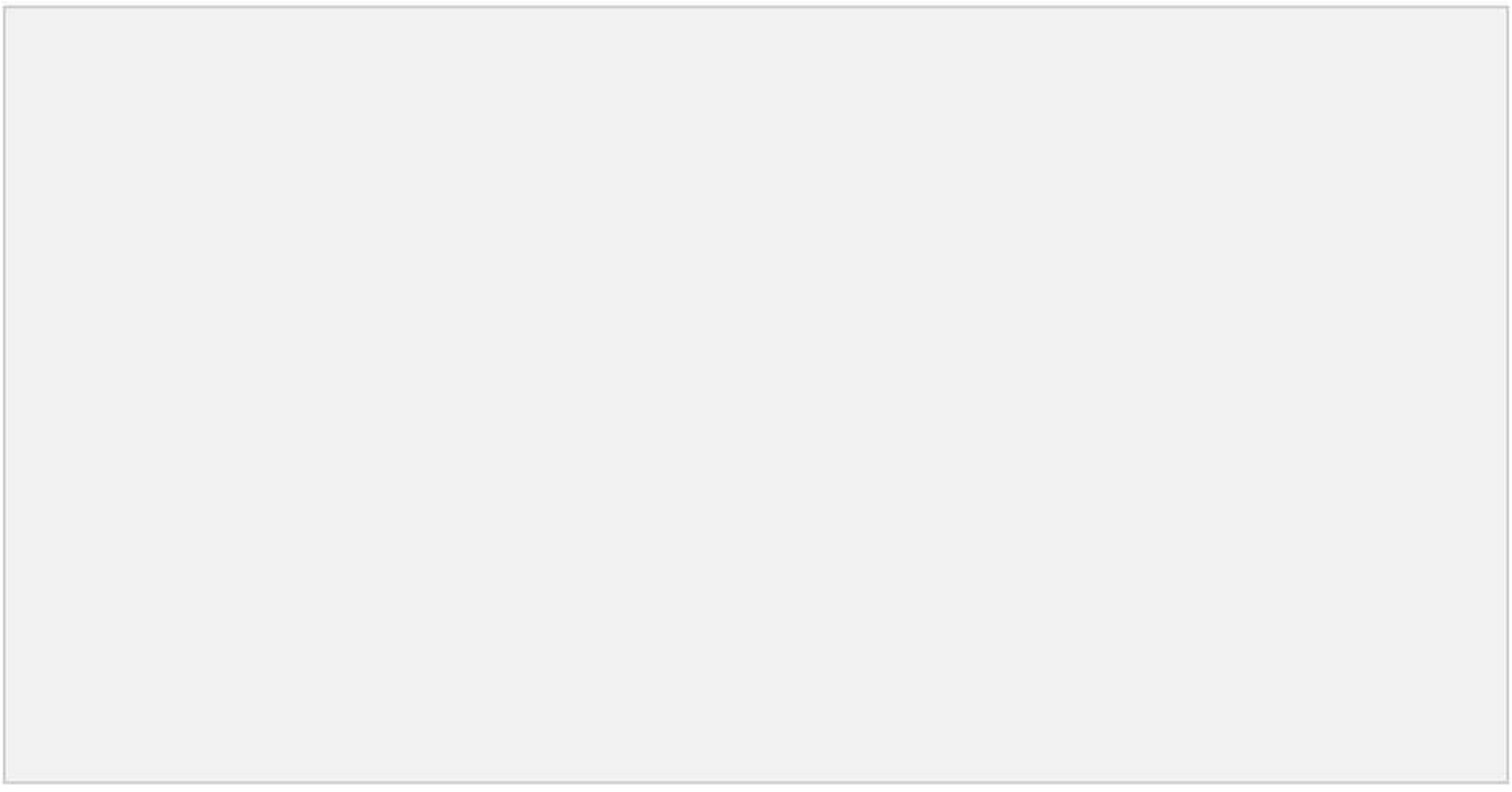
And along the way, you may just discover something unexpected: not only a deeper understanding of Scripture, but a deeper understanding of yourself. Because the Hebrew Bible is not just a book about God. It is a book about what it means to be human in relationship with the Divine.

So let us begin. Let us return. Let us listen again to the words as they were first breathed—and let them breathe life into us.

1

SHALOM

Peace: The Word We Thought We Knew



If there is one Hebrew word the world seems to recognize, it is *SHALOM*. It echoes in greetings and farewells, sung in synagogues, whispered in prayers, stitched onto banners, and spoken in longing. It is most often translated as "peace," but this English equivalent only touches the surface—like calling the ocean "wet."

SHALOM is not merely the absence of conflict. It is the presence of wholeness. It is not just a ceasefire between enemies. It is the restoration of harmony between all things—within ourselves, with one another, with creation, and with God. It speaks of integration where there was fragmentation, of mending what was torn, of paying what was owed, of completing what was missing.

To encounter the word SHALOM in Hebrew Scripture is to step into a vision of the world as it was meant to be.

One Root, Many Rivers

Hebrew is a language of roots. The root of SHALOM — *shin-lamed-mem* — is shared by words like *shalem* (complete, whole), *leshalem* (to pay or make restitution), and *mushlam* (perfect). To be at shalom is to be whole. Nothing lacking, nothing broken.

It's not just about emotions or circumstances—it's about condition. Spiritual condition. Social condition. Even economic and physical condition. That's why SHALOM can mean welfare, prosperity, safety, health, harmony, and perfection—all at once.

We see this expansive meaning in biblical usage. In Judges 6:24, Gideon names his altar "YHWH SHALOM"—*"The Lord is peace."* Not just the bringer of peace. Not just peaceful. But Peace itself. Wholeness itself. The Source from which all harmony flows.

When we greet one another with "Shalom," we're not just saying, "I hope you're doing okay." We are saying: "May you be whole. May you be as you were meant to be."

When Peace Becomes a Person

In the life and ministry of Jesus, SHALOM takes on flesh. He didn't just teach peace; He embodied it. He didn't just pronounce forgiveness; He became the reconciliation.

The brokenness between God and humanity—He stepped into it. Not as a warrior bent on destruction, but as a suffering servant who bore our wounds to make us whole.

Isaiah prophesied it plainly: *"He was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our **peace** was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed"* (Isaiah 53:5).

Jesus is not just the "Prince of Peace" in the poetic sense. He is the One who restores the universe to its original harmony. He pays the debt *(leshalem)* no one else could. He forgives, reconciles, and completes. In Him, we see the full force of SHALOM unleashed—not as an abstract principle, but as a living reality.

The False Messiah of the Sword

But here is where the meaning of SHALOM is often tragically lost—even within Christian theology. Some have imagined a Messiah who wages war to bring peace, who returns as a cosmic general to slay the wicked and dominate the earth by force.

This view, fueled by certain readings of apocalyptic texts, especially Revelation,[1] paints Jesus as a contradiction: the Lamb who becomes a lion only to renounce His own gospel of nonviolence. It imagines that the Sermon on the Mount was temporary—a soft interlude before the swords are drawn.

But such an image distorts the Messiah's mission. It replaces SHALOM with subjugation.

Killing enemies is not peace. It is victory—but a hollow one. You can silence voices with violence, but you cannot restore hearts. You can conquer a nation, but you cannot reconcile a soul.

The Myth of Peace by Elimination

Let's face the logic: If peace could be achieved by exterminating those who threaten it, then history would have resolved our conflicts long ago. But wars do not end war. They simply rearrange the players and deepen the wounds.

Fundamentalism—whether religious or political—often assumes that if we could just remove the bad people, peace would bloom. But this is an illusion. The line between good and evil does not run between groups. It runs through every human heart.

Even the Church has not escaped this deception. From the medieval crusades to the religious wars of Europe, Christians have shed the blood of many millions in the name of the Prince of Peace. And what did it bring? More division. More trauma. More wounded soldiers of the Kingdom shot down by their own.

A dear friend of mine, who leads a global ministry, once lamented, "Christians are the only army that shoots its own wounded." That, sadly, is often true. I've experienced it myself. And it is the opposite of SHALOM.

Peace Begins Where Reconciliation Begins

True SHALOM is not imposed from the outside. It begins deep within, where the human soul collides with grace. Jesus did not come to appease an angry God. He came to reveal the true face of God—a Father who runs toward prodigals, who forgives seventy times seven, who lays down His own life for enemies.

When Christ reconciled us to God, He wasn't satisfying divine wrath—He was shattering the illusion that God is like the pagan deities who demand blood to be pacified. Jesus didn't die to change God's heart about us. He died to change our hearts about God. This is the scandal of divine love: that while we were still enemies, Christ embraced us. And in that embrace, we were made whole.

This is SHALOM. Not tolerance. Not truce. But radical restoration.

Once we see this clearly, we must never again imagine that the Messiah's mission is to return as a blood-soaked avenger. The Lamb does not switch tactics. He remains the Lamb.

Not Pacifism, But Peacemaking

To be clear, affirming SHALOM is not a call to naïve pacifism. The world is broken. Evil exists. Because "love always protects" (1 Corinthians 13:7), there are times when force must be used to protect the innocent, to restrain chaos, to uphold justice. The work of police officers, soldiers, and judges is not dismissed. Scripture acknowledges this.

But here is the key: protection is not extermination. Justice is not vengeance. And the SHALOM Jesus brings is not achieved through domination—it is born through sacrifice, humility, and love that costs everything.

This is why Jesus didn't just teach about peace—He absorbed violence without passing it on. He ended the cycle of retaliation by letting it die with Him on the cross.

SHALOM as a Way of Life

The kingdom of God is not built on the ruins of its enemies. It is built wherever love mends what hatred has broken. Romans 14:17 reminds us: *"The kingdom of God is not a matter of eating and drinking, but of righteousness, SHALOM, and joy in the Holy Spirit."*

This kind of peace changes everything. It shapes how we handle conflict, how we forgive, how we resist evil without becoming evil ourselves. It changes how we raise children, how we speak truth, how we pray for enemies.

SHALOM is not just something we receive. It is something we're called to extend.

Cosmic Peace

The vision of SHALOM doesn't stop with personal inner peace or interpersonal harmony. It expands to include all of creation. Isaiah's prophecy speaks of a time when *"the wolf will dwell with the lamb... and the earth will be full of the knowledge of the Lord"* (Isaiah 11:6–9). Revelation echoes the same image—a renewed heaven and earth, tears wiped away, no more death, no more curse.

The end of the story is not destruction. It is restoration. Eden, healed. Creation, reconciled. The lion and the lamb, not just lying down together—but becoming the new order of things.

This is SHALOM in its fullest sense—a cosmic harmony, where every fracture is healed, every injustice is reversed, and every creature lives in rhythm with the Creator's heart.

Living in SHALOM Today

So, what does it mean to live a life of SHALOM now?

It means we pursue wholeness in every dimension:

In our relationship with God, through humility and trust.

In our relationships with enemies, through forgiveness, compassion, and courage.

In our relationship with ourselves, by rejecting shame and embracing grace.

And in our relationship with creation, by being caretakers, not just consumers.

We become peacemakers—not just peace-wishers. And peacemaking is often painful. It means stepping into conflict with healing, not weapons. It means being misunderstood. It means absorbing insults without retaliating. It means standing between enemies and saying, "There's another way."

Jesus said, *"Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called children of God."* Not the peace**keepers**. Not the avoiders. The **makers**—the builders, the restorers, the healers. That is our calling.

The Prince of Peace Still Reigns

To know SHALOM is to know God. For He is not just peaceful. He is peace. He doesn't just desire our wholeness—He is our wholeness.

Israel and the Middle East are noisy with war, division, and spiritual fragmentation. But it was right here that Jesus spoke over the chaos: *"Peace I leave with you; my peace I give you. Not as the world gives..."* (John 14:27). His peace is not fragile. It is not circumstantial. It is rooted in reconciliation, in divine love that does not let go.

As we learn to walk in that peace, to dwell in that wholeness, and to extend that restoration to others, we become ambassadors of SHALOM—partners in the healing of the world.

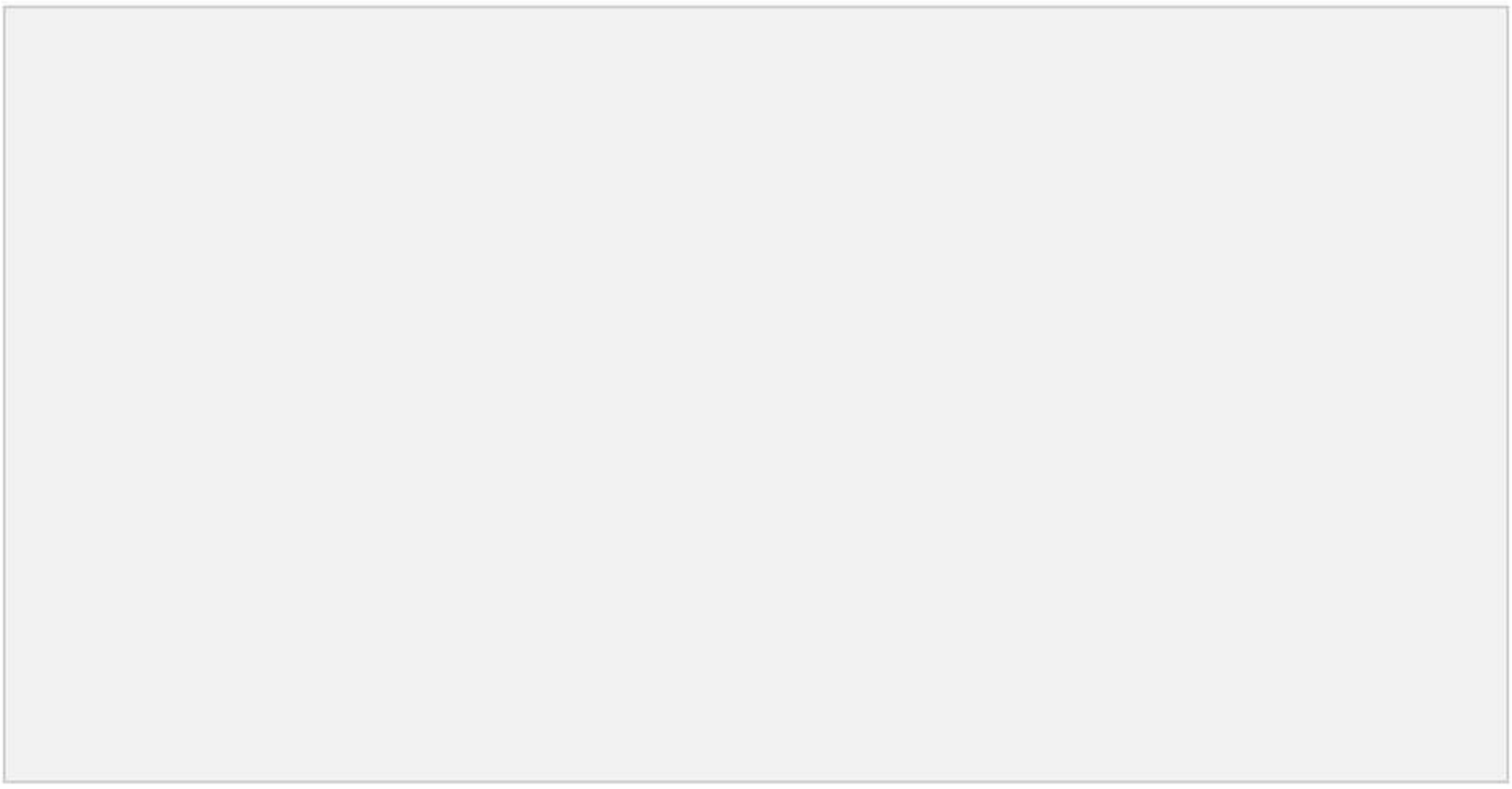
Let this word become more than a word. Let it become a rhythm in your breath, a posture in your heart, a compass in your relationships. Let it slow you down. Let it awaken you. Let it heal what is broken.

And when the world demands vengeance, let your life declare: **SHALOM!**

2

NAHASH

The Serpent and the Shining One



To the modern reader, the serpent of Genesis 3 seems fantastical—mythic, even absurd. A snake that speaks? Really?

For centuries, skeptics have dismissed the Garden of Eden story on this very ground. Museums and children's Bibles show Eve chatting with a coiled reptile, perched innocently in a fruit tree, whispering deceit in perfect Hebrew. But beneath that cartoonish imagery lies one of the most profound and misunderstood figures in all of Scripture.

In Hebrew, this serpent is called *NAHASH*. And the deeper one digs into this word, the more the ground begins to shift under the reader's feet. What if this "serpent" was never meant to be imagined as a snake at all—at least, not as we think of snakes today?

The Many Meanings of NAHASH

The word *NAHASH* is indeed used in Scripture to refer to serpents and snakes (e.g., Numbers 21). But like many Hebrew words, NAHASH carries more than one layer of meaning.

It comes from a three-letter root—nun-chet-shin—which means:

To hiss like a snake, to divine (as in occult practices), and to shine.

This last sense connects NAHASH to the word NEHOSHET, which means bronze or copper—a polished, gleaming metal. This root idea of shining, glowing, gleaming appears in multiple biblical texts, often associated with divine or angelic beings. Which means that NAHASH might not suggest a serpent—but a reptile-looking shining angelic being.

In fact, the International Standard Version of Genesis 3:1 translates it this way:

Now the Shining One was more clever than any animal of the field…

This is not just poetic license. It's grounded in language, tradition, and theology.

Paul, a Hebrew of Hebrews, writes that *"Satan himself masquerades as an **angel of light**."* (2 Corinthians 11:14)

John, in Revelation, speaks of *"a great fiery red dragon"* (Revelation 12:3) and *"the great dragon... that ancient serpent, called the devil, or Satan."* (Revelation 12:9)

So, who—or what—was Eve actually speaking to?

Not a Reptile, But a Rebel

According to an ancient Jewish midrash (Bereshit Rabbah 20:5), the NAHASH in Genesis was not a lowly creature slithering in the dirt—it was a radiant, upright, possibly winged being. Some rabbis describe it as an angelic entity or a celestial creature capable of speech and glory, who was only later cursed to crawl on its belly.

This interpretation harmonizes with a broader biblical worldview, one where the divine and human realms are not fully separated. In Eden, God Himself walks with humans. Even angels appear (Genesis 3:24). The supernatural and the natural mingle freely. In such a setting, it would not have been surprising for Eve to converse with a celestial being.

Indeed, Eve shows no alarm when the NAHASH speaks. Why? Because she likely recognized it as one of God's creatures—familiar, impressive, perhaps even beautiful. She had no reason to distrust it. Not yet.

The text says the NAHASH was "more crafty" (ARUM) than the other beasts—a word that can mean shrewd, cunning, or discerning. But it does not suggest evil—at least not at first. The danger wasn't in the serpent's shape. It was in his speech.

What begins as wisdom soon becomes deception.

Serpents in the Divine Realm

Biblical imagery is full of serpentine divine beings.

In Isaiah 6, God is surrounded by seraphim—fiery, winged beings whose name (SARAPH) means both "to burn" and "serpent." The same word is used in Numbers 21 to describe the "fiery serpents" that plagued Israel in the wilderness.

In fact, seraph may be understood as a fiery, serpentine being—one who radiates divine presence. These are not garden snakes. These are radiant creatures of flame and flight who dwell in God's throne room.

Even outside Israel, the ancient Near East was filled with serpent-deities associated with wisdom, immortality, and protection. Egyptian mythology revered the serpent Uraeus as a symbol of divine kingship. Mesopotamian tales often included shining, reptilian beings who guarded secrets or tempted humans.

Thus, when Genesis 3 introduces a radiant, intelligent NAHASH in Eden, ancient readers would not have seen a common snake. They would have recognized a supernatural being—perhaps a divine guardian gone rogue.

The Curse and the Fall

After deceiving Eve, the NAHASH is cursed by God:

> *Because you have done this, cursed are you... You will crawl on your belly and eat dust all the days of your life.*
>
> (Genesis 3:14)

This verse suggests that the NAHASH had not always crawled. The curse removes something—perhaps legs, wings, or both. It strips him of glory and casts him to the dirt.

Just as Adam will return to dust, so will the serpent be confined to it.

The curse evokes Egyptian imagery, where underworld serpents are humiliated and crushed beneath divine feet. It also mirrors later visions of judgment in Isaiah and Ezekiel, where rebellious kings (and the powers behind them) are cast down from heavenly heights to the grave below (see Isaiah 14, Ezekiel 28).

The fallen NAHASH becomes a symbol of rebellion—a creature once exalted, now humiliated. And this fall is echoed in the rest of the biblical story, from Eden to Revelation.

Not All Serpents Are Evil

The biblical image of the serpent is not one-dimensional. While NAHASH becomes a symbol of deception and rebellion in Genesis 3, the serpent is not universally condemned throughout Scripture. In fact, in one of the most surprising twists in the Torah, God commands Moses to craft a serpent—not as a symbol of evil, but as a means of healing.

In Numbers 21, Israel once again complains bitterly against God. In response, venomous serpents (seraphim, fiery snakes) bite the people, and many die. The same God who cursed the serpent in Eden now uses serpents as instruments of judgment. But even here, mercy triumphs over wrath.

God tells Moses to make a bronze serpent (NAHASH NEHOSHET—a word play) and lift it on a pole. Anyone bitten who looks upon it will be healed.

A serpent to save from serpents. Death lifted up to bring life. The irony is almost too rich.

Why a serpent? Why not a lamb, a dove, or a symbol of purity?

Because healing begins when we face what has wounded us. The people were not asked to look away, but to look directly at the source of their suffering—transformed by belief. The shining bronze serpent became a mirror. To look at it was to see both the consequence of sin and the promise of healing.

But they had to choose. Just like Eve in the garden. Just like us.

Some surely scoffed. “Look at a metal snake? That’s absurd.” Others obeyed. And they lived.

Jesus and the Serpent

Over a thousand years later, Jesus invokes this strange story to explain His mission:

> *Just as Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in Him may have eternal life.*
>
> (John 3:14–15)

The parallel is astonishing. Jesus likens Himself to the serpent—the very image of the curse (cf. Galatians 3:13). He who knew no sin became sin (2 Corinthians 5:21). He became what wounds us, so we can witness the consequences of sin and could be healed.

But this is not simply a theological transaction. It is a visual reversal. Jesus becomes the NAHASH NEHOSHET—the shining one lifted high. And we are invited to look—not just glance, but behold, think, meditate, understand—and believe.

At the cross, we see humanity's sin at its worst: betrayal, cowardice, violence, hypocrisy, mockery, torture. We see all the venom of the human soul distilled into one grotesque moment: the murder of Messiah.

But we also see something else. We see light.

The cross, like the bronze serpent, gleams with a terrible beauty. It is the place where death is not denied, but defeated. Where shame is not hidden, but healed. Where we meet the truly Shining One. Not the one once fallen, but the Shining Savior.

When we look to the cross, we are not simply asked to feel guilty. We are asked to see ourselves—our brokenness, our rebellion, our need. But also, we are asked to see what God has done about it.

He did not abandon us. He became the cure.

From Tree of Knowledge to Tree of Life

In Eden, humanity reached for a tree to take what was not theirs—knowledge, control, power. The result was exile, shame, and death.

On Calvary, Messiah hangs on a tree—not to punish, but to forgive. Not to take, but to give.

The serpent had said, "Your eyes will be opened." And they were—but only to their own nakedness.

Jesus now says, "Look to Me, and live." And our eyes are opened again—not to shame, but to grace.

The cross becomes the new Tree of Life. What was once a place of execution is now a place of resurrection. What was a symbol of cursedness becomes the doorway to Eden restored.

This is why the early Church saw Christ crucified as a second Eden. Not only was Jesus the Second Adam, but the cross was the reversal of the first temptation. The serpent deceived by promising life. Jesus redeems by giving it.

The Shining One Redeemed

Ironically, NAHASH—"the shining one"—finds its truest fulfillment not in the deceiver of Eden, but in the Redeemer of all creation. The enemy still masquerades as an angel of light, offering illusions of glory without sacrifice, brilliance without love. But Jesus is not a masquerade—He is the Light itself.

Where Satan seduces with the glitter of false wisdom, Jesus invites with the fire of self-giving love. His glory is not borrowed; it is born of being.

Revelation describes Him with eyes like flames, feet like burnished bronze, and *"a face like the sun shining in all its brilliance"* (Revelation 1:16). This is no borrowed glow—it is the very radiance of divine glory. As Hebrews declares,

> *The Son is the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of His being.*
>
> (Hebrews 1:3)

Jesus is the true Shining One—the radiance that does not deceive, the brilliance that does not fade, the glory that does not consume but calls us home.

The serpent sought glory without obedience. Jesus embraced obedience and was glorified.

The serpent corrupted through lies. Jesus restores through truth.

The serpent brought death through pride. Jesus brings life through humility.

Where the NAHASH in Genesis slithered into rebellion, Jesus shines in obedience, showing us not only what God is, but who we can become.

Looking at the Cross Today

Golgotha stands as the summit of humanity's darkest crimes—pride, rivalry, scapegoating, violence, and the lust for domination—all laid bare and brought under judgment. It was the moment when human civilization, with all its claims of order and justice, was unmasked for what it truly is: a power struggle maintained by violence so corrupt that it did not hesitate to crucify God Himself in the name of "truth" and "righteousness."

Yet Golgotha is not only the site of humanity's greatest sin—it is also the place where we encounter the greatest revelation of divine love. There, in the suffering of Christ, we see sacrificial love in its purest and most powerful form: a love that absorbs violence without returning it, that forgives while being pierced, and that conquers not by killing, but by dying.

Thus, to gaze at the cross is to see more than wood and nails. It is to see every twisted impulse of the human heart exposed—and every wound answered by grace.

The lies we believed—He took them. The shame we carry—He bore it. The judgment we deserve—He absorbed it. But that's not the end.

Because the cross is not just a mirror—it's a window. Through it, we see what God is like. A God who shines, not with pride or vengeance, but with sacrificial love.

A God who walks through our venom to heal us. A God who takes the very image of the curse—and transforms it into salvation.

In the end, the serpent is not just a villain in a garden. He is a shadow of something deeper—our capacity to fall, to deceive, to want wisdom without humility. But the cross is God's answer to every NAHASH in our lives.

Where we see death, God offers life. Where we see judgment, He offers mercy. Where we see darkness, He becomes light.

The cross is not only a place of atonement. It is a place of revelation.

It shows us what we are capable of. But more importantly, it shows us what God is capable of.

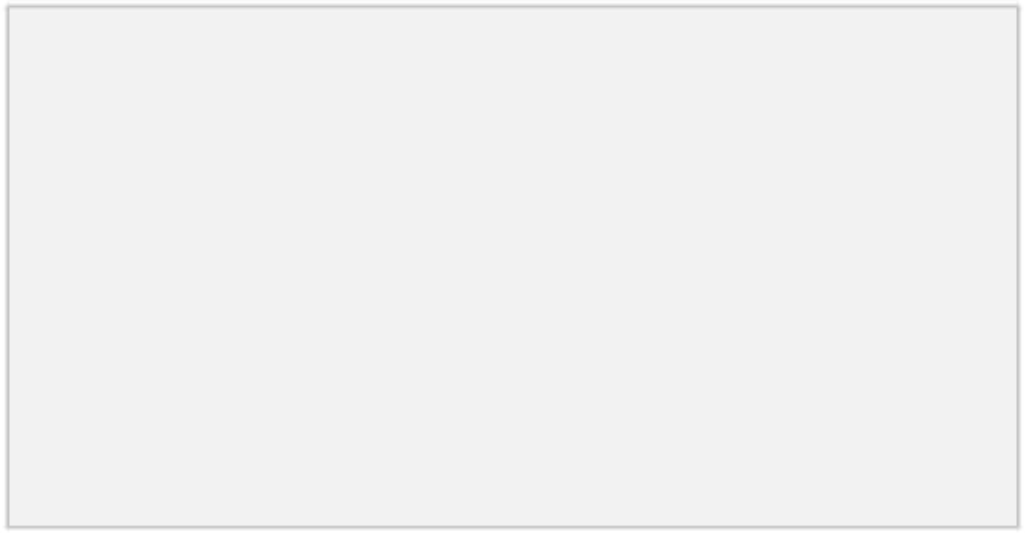
> *And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw all people to Myself.*
>
> (John 12:32)

The cross is lifted. The Shining One is raised. The serpent is reversed.

And all who look to Him—who behold the glory in the gore, the light in the blood—will live.

QORBAN

Sacrifice: A Word of Closeness, Not Cruelty



In most people's minds, the word sacrifice evokes images of blood, death, and loss. In the modern West, it often carries a negative tone—something you're forced to give up, something painful, something you endure reluctantly. But in the ancient Hebrew mind, sacrifice had a completely different connotation. It was not about destruction. It was about connection.

The Hebrew word for sacrifice is *QORBAN*. It shares a root with the word *QAROV*, which means "near," "close," "intimate." In other words, a *QORBAN* is not about death. It is about coming near.

In biblical Hebrew, the root Q-R-B forms words for warmth, proximity, nearness, kinship, and even giblets. If someone is your relative, they are your *QAROV*—your close one. And if you want to draw near to God, you bring a *QORBAN*—a gift of nearness.

Sacrifice, in the biblical sense, is not about punishment. It's about relationship. It is about removing barriers and restoring closeness.

Giving as an Act of Intimacy

Think of the sacrifices you've made in life—not religious ones, but real, human ones. When have you given something up for the sake of someone you loved? When have you surrendered time, comfort, pride, or possessions to bless another? You weren't punishing yourself or trying to pay a cosmic debt. You were expressing love. You were drawing near.

A mother who wakes in the night to tend to a crying child. A friend who donates a kidney. A soldier who shields a comrade. These are acts of *QORBAN*. They cost something—but their goal is intimacy, protection, and love. The gift is not the pain. The gift is the nearness.

This was the heart behind the sacrificial system in Israel. To draw near to God, one brought something valuable—grain, oil, wine, livestock. Not to feed God. Not to pacify an angry God. But to express devotion. To enact closeness. The blood, the fire, the aroma—these were not violence for its own sake. They were symbols of surrender. Of approach. Of relational restoration.

Misunderstood Offerings: The Pagan Inheritance

Unfortunately, much of Christian theology has inherited its understanding of sacrifice not from the Hebrew Scriptures, but from Greco-Roman and pagan frameworks. In those systems, the gods were hungry, angry, unstable, and had to be bribed or soothed with blood.

Sacrifice in that worldview was appeasement. “The gods are angry. Someone must die. Let’s kill an animal—or a person—to keep them off our backs.”

This idea has subtly crept into some Christian atonement theories, where God’s wrath is imagined as requiring violence to be satisfied. But this vision is a distortion of biblical truth. It turns God into the very kind of deity Israel was warned against emulating.

A theologian I highly respect is Tim Mackie, the creator of the renowned animated video series "The Bible Project." In a podcast critiquing the John Calvin's Penal Substitution Atonement theory, he stated:

Many of us [in the West] have inherited a story about animal sacrifice, and it goes something like this:

“The gods are angry with me and are going to kill me. But maybe if I kill this animal and make sure the gods get their pound of flesh, they’ll be appeased and happy. Maybe they won’t kill me or send a plague on my family. Sure, it’s barbaric, but so are the gods…”

Much of popular Christian belief has simply imported a pagan storyline into Leviticus and the stories about Jesus’ death on the cross. The result is a tragic irony. What the Bible is portraying as an expression of God’s love gets twisted into something dark. Our version goes like this:

"God is holy and perfect. You are not. Therefore, God is angry at you, and hates you even, so he has to kill you. But because he's merciful, he'll let you bring this animal to him and will have the animal killed instead of you. Thankfully, Jesus came to be the one who gets killed by God instead of me. Jesus rescues us from God, so now we can go forever to the happy place after we die and not the bad place."

Is this story recognizable to you? If so, you're not alone. The main problem with this story, to be a bit snarky, is the Bible. More specifically, the problem is that this story has enough biblical language in it that it can pass for what the Bible actually says about animal sacrifice and Jesus' death. However, when you step back and allow Leviticus and the New Testament to speak for themselves, you can recognize this story as an imposter.[2]

Tim Mackie

As Dr. Tim Mackie wisely pointed out, much of modern atonement theology retells a pagan story with biblical language. In this story, Jesus becomes the whipping boy who takes the beating so we can go free—while God watches, satisfied. But this is not the God revealed in the Hebrew Scriptures. It is not the God revealed in Jesus.

Now, let's disregard everything we've been taught and examine what sacrifices were during ancient times.

Sacrifice Was Never Abuse

In the Hebrew Scriptures, sacrificial animals were treated with reverence. Slaughter was to be quick, humane, precise. The offering was not tortured. It was not "punished." No one flogged the animal to transfer guilt. The act was sacred—not violent.

Maimonides, the revered medieval Jewish philosopher, wrote that the rules of ritual slaughter were given to minimize the animal's pain. The goal was never destruction.

It was transformation. A symbolic transfusion of life, *"for the life of the flesh is in the blood..."* (Leviticus 17:11)

To say Jesus was our sacrifice is true—but we must ask: what kind of sacrifice? According to which scriptural pattern? If we project violence onto the cross as if it pleased God to see His Son suffer (a grotesque misreading of Isaiah 53:10), we are not following Scriptures. We are following Marcion. We are adhering to Calvinism. We are projecting pagan categories onto the Hebrew Bible.

Jesus was not punished by the Father. He was given by the Father. He was not abused to satisfy wrath. He was lifted up in love to remove the barrier of fear between us and God.

Qorban and the Gift Economy of Love

To give a korban is to offer a gift. Not a bribe. Not a plea bargain. But a symbol of relationship.

William K. Gilders, a scholar of ancient religion, explains:

> One way to think about ancient sacrifices is as "gifts" given to God. When they performed sacrifices, ancient Israelites gave to God some of what they believed God had given them, expressing their close relationship with God and seeking to deepen that bond.[3]

This aligns perfectly with how love works. When someone gives you something meaningful—a hand-written letter, a favorite book, a handmade item—it's not about price. It's about presence. The object carries the weight of the heart behind it.

The same is true in our relationship with God. In Hosea 6:6, God declares: *"I desire mercy, not sacrifice; and knowledge of God more than burnt offerings."* That is: what I want is your heart. Your love. Your nearness.

God was never hungry for blood. He was always hungry for connection.

Jesus, the Living QORBAN

In the life, teachings, and death of Jesus, the concept of QORBAN reaches its highest expression—not as a slaughtered hostage appeasing a wrathful deity, but as the fullest embodiment of self-giving love. He gave not to satisfy divine rage but to draw us near. He poured out His life, not to change God's mind about us—but to change our hearts about God.

Jesus reframed the entire sacrificial system. When asked what offerings pleased God, He pointed not to killing or temple rituals, but to love in action (e.g., Matthew 5:23–24, 19:21).

The new altar is the heart. The new QORBAN is the gift of reconciliation, generosity, justice, and mercy. Jesus didn't abolish sacrifice—He transfigured it.

As Hebrews 13:16 says:

> "Do not forget to do good and to share with others, for with such sacrifices God is pleased."

The offerings that please God are not rituals of blood, but acts of compassion. The smoke that rises now is the aroma of kindness.

The Field Trip Theology of Sacrifice

Oddly enough, the meaning of QORBAN is something we all understood as children—before we were taught otherwise.

Imagine the school field trip. You're seated on a bus. You brought snacks—your favorite ones. They're precious. But you see a friend with none. So, you offer them yours. Maybe not the cheap ones, but the good ones—the ones that matter.

That gesture is sacrifice. Not because it hurts, but because it heals. It says: "You matter more to me than what I'm giving up." It binds hearts. It creates belonging.

Ancient Israel understood this too. They gave from their best—not because God was hungry or angry, but because God was worthy. They offered to draw near, to say "Thank You," to restore brokenness. They weren't buying salvation. They were building relationship.

Even the idea of celebration was built into sacrifice. After offerings, many festivals followed. Joy, food, community. It was never about appeasing divine rage. It was about returning home to God's table.

Sacrifice as a Language of Relationship

Gift-giving still follows this rhythm. The value is not in the object, but in what it represents. A diamond ring costs much, but it means more than its price. It symbolizes commitment. Presence. Closeness.

Likewise, when we give our time, our energy, our pride, our status—these too are QORBAN. Even our pain can become sacrifice, when we choose to suffer with others instead of remaining aloof. This is what Paul meant when he wrote, *"Present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God—this is your spiritual worship"* (Romans 12:1).

The true altar is life itself.

What Ancient Sacrifices Actually Meant

To understand QORBAN, we must remember: in ancient Israel, animals were not anonymous property. They were cared for, named, and raised like family. Offering one was costly not just financially, but emotionally. It was a sign of surrender, not savagery.

The Torah (the Law of Moses) required that the animal be unblemished—whole, sound. The act of slaughter was to be quick and humane. There was no abuse, no torture, no venting of anger upon the animal. If this is true of the shadow, how much more the substance?

If Jesus is our sacrifice in the spirit of Torah, then His death must not be seen as a punishment from the Father, but as the ultimate offering of love from the Son.

The "Gospel" of Divine Abuse

Consider a husband who hurts his wife and wants to apologize. He buys her flowers and chocolates—not to be destroyed, but to say "I'm sorry. I love you. I want to be close again."

Now imagine she takes the gifts, stomps them into the floor, and says, "Now I feel better. Your gifts absorbed my anger. I forgive you."

That's absurd.

And yet this is the reasoning many were taught in their churches, particularly among Fundamentalist denominations (e.g., Baptists, Calvinists, Pentecostals, Evangelicals) — that God was so furious at humanity, He needed to take it out on someone—and Jesus became the object of that wrath.

But that is not the story of Scripture. In the Gospels, Jesus doesn't die to change God's disposition toward us. He dies to reveal God's eternal disposition of love.

The real tragedy is not just the violence of this story—it's that it hides a far more beautiful truth. A truth we already see in the Hebrew Scriptures, if we would just return to them.

I know I'm only scratching the surface here—and you may have questions or even objections. If so, I invite you to explore these ideas further in my short book, ***The "Gospel" of Divine Abuse: Redeeming the Gospel from Gruesome Popular Preaching of an Abusive and Violent God***.

The Way Back Home

True sacrifice is always about one thing: nearness. QORBAN is the language of return. It says: "I want to come closer. I want to restore what was broken."

And this, ultimately, is what Jesus offered us. Not a loophole. Not a courtroom drama. But a path home.

He invited us to bring our hearts to the altar—not to be crushed, but to be healed. Not to satisfy a wrathful deity, but to share in the divine life.

We are now called to walk in that same love. To become QORBAN—living sacrifices—not in death, but in daily acts of compassion, courage, and connection.

The call of discipleship is not to carry guilt, but to carry love into a broken world.

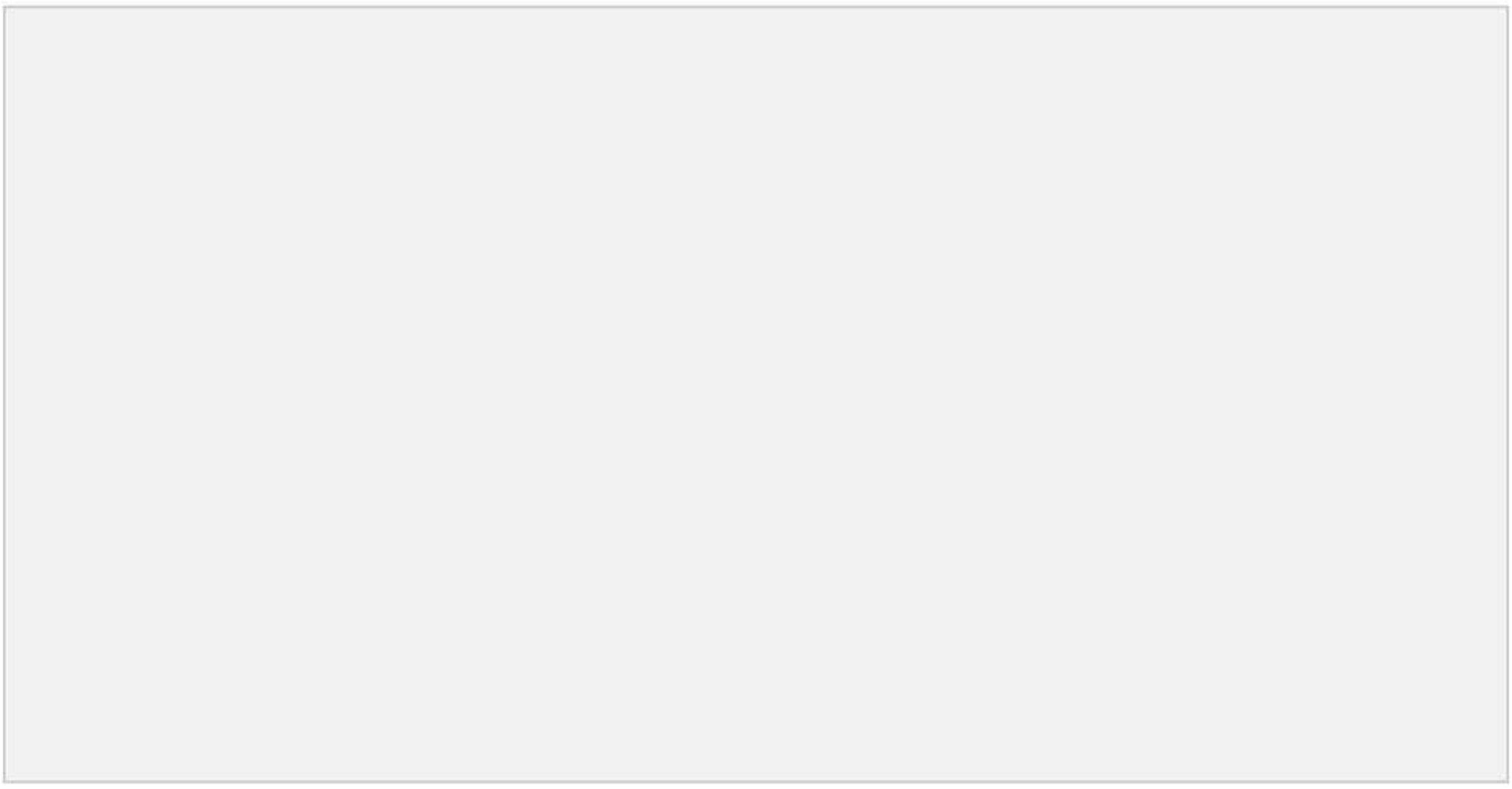
So let us make our lives an offering. Let us give our time, our presence, our resources, our hearts. Not to earn God's favor—but to express it.

This is QORBAN. And through it, we draw near to one another, to God, and even to our enemies.

4

DAM

Blood: The River of Life



What Blood Has Become—and What It Once Meant

We live in a world where blood usually signals one thing: violence. We see it splattered across war zones on the evening news. We play games that reward it. We watch films that glorify it. In modern consciousness, blood has become the language of trauma, danger, and death. We hide it in hospitals. We wipe it away with latex gloves. We associate it not with life, but with loss.

But Scripture tells a different story.

To the ancient Hebrews, blood was not grotesque. It was sacred. Not a sign of pain, but a carrier of life. Not a horror, but a hope. The Torah never portrays blood as a symbol of God's anger—it portrays it as a medium of reconciliation through purification — a divine antiseptic for the sake of divine presence.

In Hebrew, the word ADAM — meaning "man" or "human" — is closely connected to the word DAM, which means “blood.” This linguistic link highlights the profound biblical concept that human life is inextricably tied to blood, both physically and spiritually:

> **DAM** = Blood.
> **ADAM** = Adam (the first man)
> **ADAMAH** = Ground.

At the heart of this vision is a verse many overlook:

> *For the life of the creature is in the **blood**, and I have given it to you to make atonement… It is the blood that makes atonement, for the life is in it.*
>
> (Leviticus 17:11)

The power isn’t in the death. The power is in the life—and that life flows in blood.

Life Given, Not Death Demanded

In the sacrificial system of ancient Israel, blood wasn't spilled to appease God's anger. It was offered because life had been lost—and God, in His mercy, provided a way to restore it. It was never death that made atonement, but blood. And blood meant life.

So, the altar was not a stage for divine punishment. It was a table of reunion. A meeting place between holiness and humanity. Blood did not feed a hungry God—it healed a fractured people.

God says: "I have given it to you." That is not the language of wrath. That is the language of gift.

This understanding stands in direct contrast to the pagan religions surrounding Israel. In those cultures, blood was about appeasement. Sacrifices were bribes. Offerings were threats. The gods were angry, unstable, and needed to be fed with blood. But the God of Israel did not eat. He did not rage. He gave life.

The animal wasn't abused, flogged, or tortured for its blood. The idea that a loving Father would demand the abuse of a sacrifice to forgive His children is a foreign intrusion. It reflects pagan logic, not biblical theology.

The Scandal of Life in the Blood

In biblical thought, blood was never about gore—it was about glory. It was the visible stream of invisible life. It carried the breath of God through the veins of living beings. It pulsed with purpose. It was the sign that something was still alive, still animated by divine breath.

That's why blood purifies. It doesn't do so by magic or violence—it does so because it represents the return of life where death had crept in.

This is also why impurity in the Law wasn't about shame or guilt. It was about proximity to death. A corpse, an open wound, a flow of blood or semen—these were not moral evils. They were reminders that death touched us. And God, being the God of life, required that death be addressed before His people could draw near.

So, what did God provide? Blood.

Not to terrify, but to cleanse. Not to pay, but to restore. Not to punish, but to purify.

The Altar and the Operating Table

We don't usually think of ancient worship in terms of hygiene. Yet the rituals of the Tabernacle were strangely familiar in one regard: they were obsessed with cleanliness. Not physical cleanliness, though that mattered too, but spiritual sterility—the removal of defilement so that the presence of the living God could remain among His people.

In our post-pandemic world, the idea of sterilizing spaces resonates more than ever. We use bleach, alcohol gel, disinfectants. A surgeon will not step into an operating room until it is spotless. Not because the doctor is angry at germs—but because the presence of contamination would endanger life. Not because the doctor is cruel—but because the space is sacred. Life is at stake. Contamination must be removed so healing can take place.

The Tabernacle was no different. It, too, was a kind of hospital—but not for bodies. For souls. And in this holy hospital, blood was the antiseptic. The priest, like a spiritual physician, would carry life in liquid form and apply it to sacred objects that had been touched by the impurity of a fallen world.

We read in Exodus:

> *He shall take some of the bull's blood and some of the goat's blood and put it on all the horns of the altar… sprinkle some of the blood with his finger seven times to cleanse it and consecrate it from the uncleanness of the Israelites.*
>
> Leviticus 16:18–19

The Blood was never about wrath. It was about sanctification. About purification. About life.

The Altar Must Be Sterilized — Blood as Spiritual Antiseptic

The ancient Tabernacle was, metaphorically speaking, a holy hospital for the soul. The blood acted as a spiritual antiseptic, not punishing objects or people, but purifying them so God's presence could dwell among them.

We see this clearly:

> *He shall sprinkle the **blood**… to cleanse and consecrate it from the uncleanness of the Israelites.*
>
> (Leviticus 16:18–19)

> *Moses took the **blood**… and purified the altar.*
>
> (Leviticus 8:15)

Did the altar sin? Of course not. But it dwelled in a death-saturated world. And for God's Spirit to remain, the space had to be sanctified.

Now consider this: if blood purified the furniture of the Tabernacle, what does Jesus' blood purify? Us. Our consciences. Our inner altars. Our hearts.

As Hebrews 9:14 says:

> *How much more will the **blood** of Christ… purify our consciences from dead works to serve the living God?*

That's the real scandal of the cross—not that Jesus was punished, but that His blood was poured out like a divine transfusion. It entered death and flushed it with immortal life.

Jesus, the Living Temple

In Jesus, the entire sacrificial system takes on flesh. He is not merely the Lamb. He is also the Temple, the High Priest, and the Altar. Every symbol that pointed to God's presence, purity, and power now finds its fullness in Him. And when He offers His blood, He is not offering it to an angry Father demanding revenge—He is offering it to a broken world in need of restoration.

His blood does not scream punishment. It sings peace.

The book of Hebrews affirms this again and again:

> *He entered the Most Holy Place once for all by His own **blood**, thus obtaining eternal redemption.*
>
> (Hebrews 9:12)

The emphasis is always the same: it is the blood—the life—of Jesus that cleanses, sanctifies, and reconciles. Not His pain. Not His punishment. But His life offered in love:

*…we have **redemption** through his **blood**, the forgiveness of sins…*

(Ephesians 1:7)

*…to make the people **holy** through his own **blood**…*

(Hebrews 13:12)

*…him who loves us and has **freed** us from our sins by his **blood**…"*

(Revelation 1:5)

*…we have now been **justified** by his **blood**…*

(Romans 5:9)

*…we have **redemption** through his **blood**…*

(Ephesians 1:7)

*…have been **brought near** by the **blood** of Christ…*

(Ephesians 2:13)

*…making **peace** through his **blood**, shed on the cross…*

(Colossians 1:20)

*…you were **redeemed**…with the precious **blood** of Christ…*

(1 Peter 1:18-19)

*…the **blood** of Jesus, his Son, **purifies** us from all sin…*

(1 John 1:7)

The cross is not the climax of divine fury—it is the climax of divine mercy

Atonement Was Never a Bloodbath

In the Jewish world of the Bible, atonement (KIPPUR) never meant "someone has to be destroyed." It meant cleansing. Covering. Returning things to their original state of purity. Blood wasn't poured out to pay a fine. It was applied like balm to heal and sanctify what death had touched.

That's why the animal wasn't punished before it died. It wasn't shamed. It wasn't abused. Its blood was carefully handled—not to satisfy wrath, but to purify what had been made impure by death.

This is where the Western Church often went wrong.

Over time, Christian theology (especially from the Middle Ages onward) began to absorb pagan assumptions: that God must punish sin through violence, that someone had to be abused in our place, that wrath had to be satisfied.

But this is not what Leviticus teaches. It's not what the Gospels proclaim. And it's certainly not what Jesus modeled.

The God of Israel does not delight in pain. He delights in mercy (Micah 7:18). His justice is not retributive—it is restorative.

His Blood, Our Transfusion

To modern ears, all this talk of blood can still sound strange. But even in medicine, we intuitively understand it. When someone is bleeding out—we transfuse them. When someone is dying, we offer, we donate, we sacrifice our own blood to save them. It's a gift, not a transaction.

This is exactly what Jesus did. Christ didn't die to satisfy divine bloodlust. He died to pour divine life into the dying human race.

He said, *"Unless you drink My blood, you have no life in you."* (John 6:53). This wasn't grotesque. It was gospel. He was saying, "If My life is in My blood, and you receive it, then My life becomes yours."

Cleansed, Not Condemned

The blood of Jesus does not cover your guilt so God can ignore it. It removes the guilt altogether. It cleanses, purifies, renews, restores. That's why the New Testament never glorifies Jesus' suffering. It glorifies His blood—not for its gore, but for its grace: *"The blood of Jesus… purifies us from all sin."* (1 John 1:7)

Why Death Was Involved—But Never the Point

It's important to be precise. The blood that atoned required death—but death was not what atoned.

The death allowed access to the blood. The blood carried the life. The life cleansed what death had corrupted.

So, while death was present, it was never the goal. It was the doorway to the deeper mystery: a life poured out in love to restore what sin had broken.

That's why Hebrews 9:22 says:

> *Without the shedding of **blood**, there is no forgiveness.*

Not because God demanded vengeance—but because forgiveness, in the biblical framework, requires life to replace what death had taken.

Blood, then, is not about death—it's about life stronger than death.

The Final Cleansing

If Leviticus 17:11 is the beginning—*"the life is in the blood"*—then Revelation 1:5 is the climax: *"He has freed us from our sins by His blood."*

Not by His torment. Not by His death alone. But by His life—freely poured out, eternally victorious.

And the goal was never just forgiveness. It was union. Restoration. Resurrection.

Now, the blood of Jesus does not sit in a past moment. It flows into your present. It is the oxygen of your spirit. The lifeblood of your new identity. You are not simply forgiven. You are alive.

Because the blood of Jesus did not just stop wrath. It started resurrection.

The gospel is not about a furious God finally appeased. It's about a loving God fully revealed. The cross was not where Jesus shielded us from the Father's wrath. It was where the Father, Son, and Spirit joined in one act of cosmic self-giving to cleanse a death-filled world with undying life.

The blood of Jesus is not a relic of violence. It is a river of grace.

So now, the only question is: Will you receive it?

Will you let that blood—the life of God—flow into the places in you still marked by death, fear, shame, guilt, or despair? Will you accept not just forgiveness, but restoration?

Because the life is in the blood. And He has given it to you. Not in part. Not in theory. But fully, eternally, and forever.

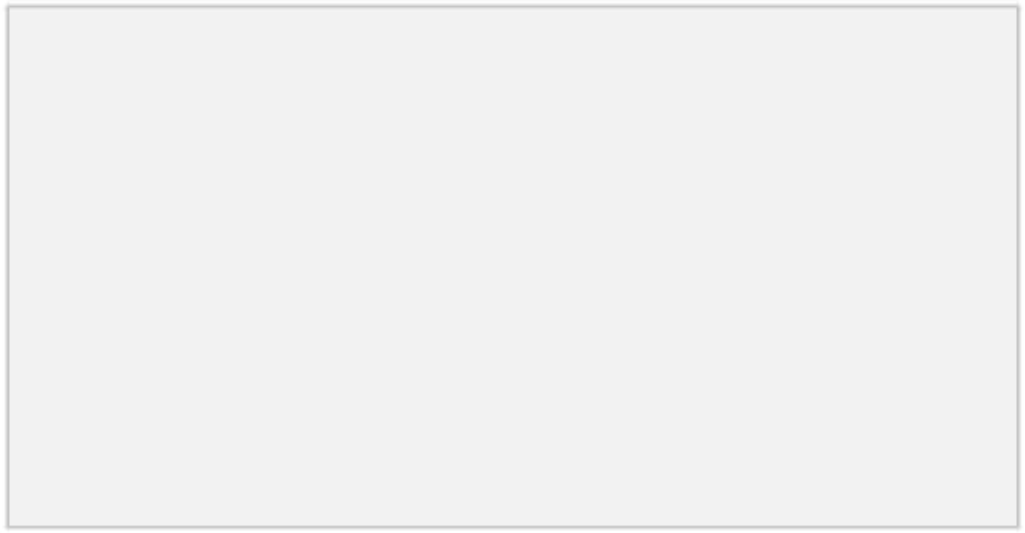
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Join me on a journey to rediscover the biblical meaning of atonement—and how its deepest truths were fulfilled in Christ—in my book ***"The Gospel Before Christianity: A Jewish Perspective on Jesus' Atonement, Sacrifice, and Redemption."***

5

BRIT

Cutting a Covenant



In Hebrew, you don't "make" a covenant. You cut one.

The Hebrew phrase is *KARAT BRIT*—literally, "to cut a covenant." The first word *(KARAT)* means to excise, amputate, sever. The second word *(BRIT)* means covenant, alliance, or sacred pact. Together, these two words carry far more than contractual implications. They evoke an image of something visceral—flesh torn, blood spilled, life bound.

That's why, when Jews perform circumcision, they call it *BRIT MILAH*—the "Covenant of Circumcision." It is, quite literally, the physical act of cutting the foreskin as a sign of entering into the covenant God made with Abraham.

In English, we sometimes preserve this old idiom in the phrase "to cut a deal," but we rarely consider what it actually means. In the world of ancient Israel, it meant blood. To enter into a covenant was to step into a life-and-death bond sealed in blood—a bond so solemn that to break it was to invite your own destruction.

But for all the gravity, brit was never about fear. It was about faithfulness.

The God of Israel was not interested in transactional agreements. He didn't need anything from His creation. The covenants He cut were not out of need—but out of love.

The Night God Cut a BRIT with Abraham

Nowhere is this clearer than in Genesis 15.

God had already spoken promises over Abraham—offspring, land, blessing. But then, in a deeply mysterious and profoundly symbolic act, He invites Abraham to seal those promises — to "cut a BRIT."

Abraham is instructed to take a heifer, a ram, a goat, a dove, and a pigeon—cut them in half (except for the birds), and arrange the pieces in two lines with a clear path down the middle. This scene may seem bizarre to modern readers, but to Abraham, it was familiar. In the ancient Near East, such rituals were a common way of "cutting a covenant." The participants would walk between the slain animals together, effectively saying: "May this happen to me if I break my word."

The covenant path was a walk of death that guaranteed life. It was a solemn vow, sealed in flesh.

But what happens next is shocking: Abraham falls into a deep sleep. A thick darkness descends. And then—only God walks through the pieces. Not Abraham. Just God.

A smoking firepot and a blazing torch—two manifestations of divine presence—pass through the pathway of blood. The meaning is clear: God is taking all the responsibility upon Himself. Abraham doesn't promise a thing. He only watches. This covenant is unilateral. God alone will bear the weight of it. God alone will fulfill it.

And God, being eternal and immortal, cannot die. Which means this promise cannot fail.

This isn't just an ancient ritual—it's a revelation. God is saying:

"I will keep My word. I will give you the blessing. I will fulfill what I promised. And if it costs Me My life to do it—so be it."

It is the gospel before the cross.

Why Would a King Cut Covenant with a Peasant?

Covenants in the ancient world were often between a powerful king and a lesser

vassal. The king would promise protection, provision, and peace. The vassal would pledge loyalty and tribute. Possibly pay a tax as well. But what does the Great King of the universe have to gain from binding Himself to dust-made creatures?

Nothing. That's the point.

God's covenants are acts of condescending love. He doesn't need anything from us. He doesn't cut covenants because He wants something. He does it because He wants us.

In the story of Abraham, God is not gaining a servant. He's adopting a son. He is declaring, "You are Mine. And I am yours. And My life is pledged to you, even if you can offer nothing in return."

This is why Abraham's only role was to believe. He wasn't required to walk through the pieces. He wasn't forced to sign a contract. He simply trusted the God who promised.

And God counted that faith as righteousness (Genesis 15:6).

Covenant as Commitment, Not Control

Modern religion often portrays God as a conditional deity—ready to bless when we obey and punish when we fail. But covenant turns this image upside down. In BRIT, God is not leveraging obedience. He's offering Himself.

He does not say: "If you measure up, I'll love you."

He says: "I love you. Walk with Me, and live."

Covenant is not a cage. It is a commitment. Not a leash—but a lifeline.

When God binds Himself to humanity, He is not tightening His grip—He is opening His heart.

Jesus: The New Covenant Cut in Eternal Blood

This brings us to Jesus.

At the Last Supper, holding a cup of wine, He says:

> *This cup is the new covenant in My blood, poured out for many.*
>
> (Luke 22:20)

He is echoing Genesis 15. Only this time, the covenant will not be cut with animals. It will be cut in His own flesh. He will walk through the blood—not humanity. He will carry the promise—not us.

This is why Paul calls the New Covenant "better"—because it's sealed not with the blood of bulls, but with the blood of God.

Hebrews 9:12 says it plainly:

> *He entered once for all into the holy places… by means of His own blood, thus securing eternal redemption.*

This is not a temporary fix. It is an eternal bond.

Jesus didn't die so God could love us. Jesus died because God already did. And now, with His life pledged and poured out, the New Covenant stands as the ultimate BRIT: a bond that no sin can break, no failure can undo, and no power can revoke.

Eternal Security, Eternal Rest

For those who struggle with assurance—who fear that their flaws or failures might separate them from God — covenant is the answer.

The New Covenant doesn't depend on your consistency. It depends on Christ's blood.

You may stumble. You may doubt. But God cut the covenant alone. It does not rest on your strength, but His. Your job is not to earn it—but to trust it. To believe, as Abraham did, that God will be faithful to His word.

That kind of covenant brings peace. Deep, immovable peace. The kind that silences fear and settles the soul.

Covenant means that God is not just our Creator—He is our Partner. He is not just Sovereign—He is faithful. He is not just holy—He is bound to us in blood.

The God who walked through the pieces in Abraham's vision is the same God who walked up Calvary.

And the blood that once marked an altar now marks a cross.

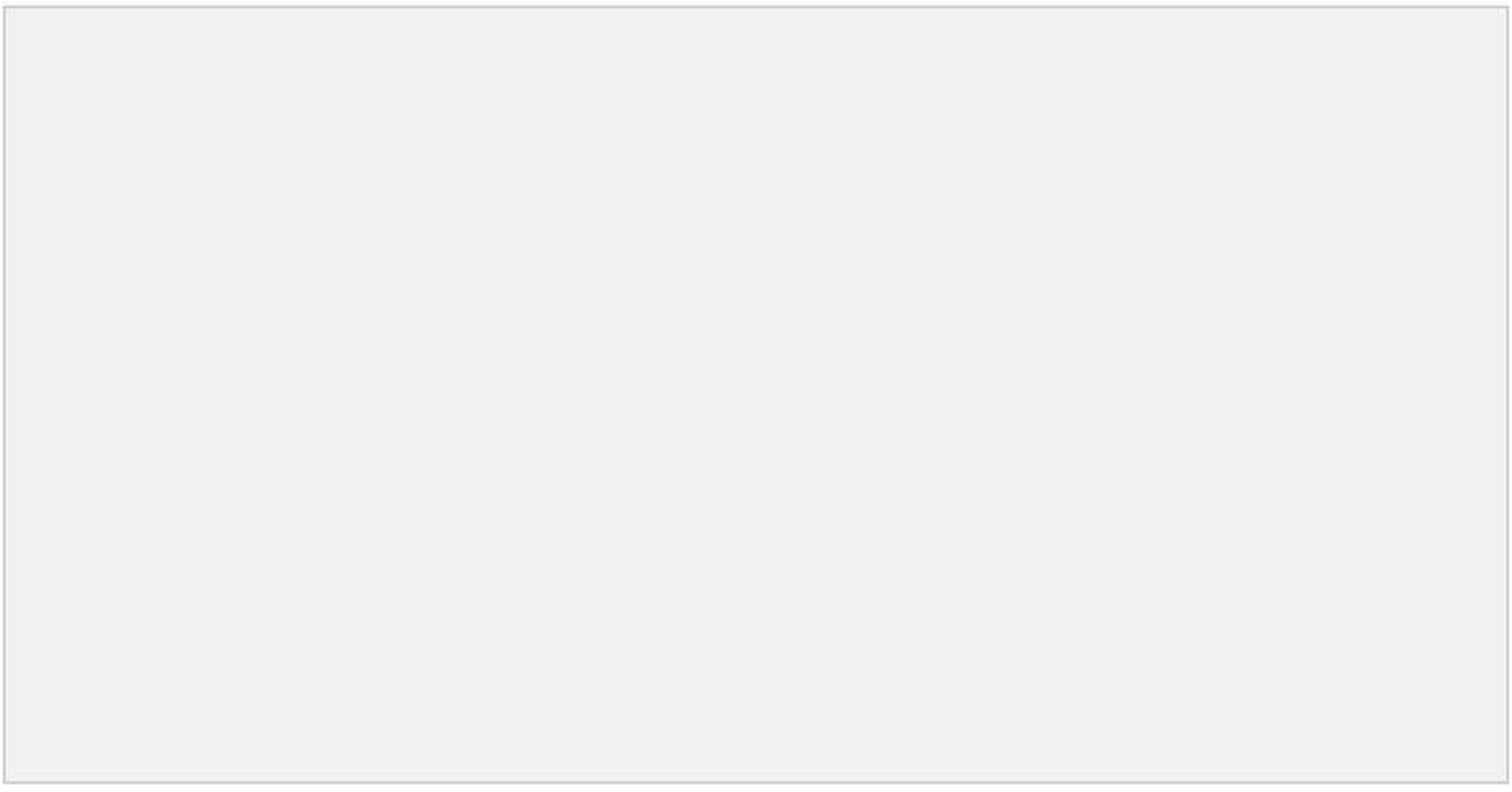
He cut a BRIT with humanity.

He pledged His life to our redemption.

And He will not break His word. Never.

EZER

Helper: Much More Than Just a Server



No story is more iconic than that of the Garden of Eden. For many, it is the origin of sin, shame, and separation. But viewed through another lens, it becomes something far more tender and profound: a love story. Not only between Adam and Eve, but between God and humanity. A God who walks in gardens, who clothes the naked, who calls out even when we hide in shame. This is not the story of a furious judge storming in—it is the portrait of a grieving parent, a faithful lover, a divine Companion who longs to be close to His creation.

The entire Bible, when seen rightly, is the unfolding of this same divine romance—a cosmic pursuit. And that vision begins, not with wrath, but with relationship. Before there is sin, there is solitude. And before there is a fall, there is a helper.

Genesis 2:18 offers a key insight:

> *The Lord God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone. I will make a **helper (EZER)** suitable for him."*

This verse has sparked centuries of debate. Is it a declaration of hierarchy—or harmony? Is the woman a subordinate servant—or a sacred support? Much depends on how we interpret one word: *EZER*.

The Helper Misunderstood

In many conservative or fundamentalist circles, this verse is used to suggest that women were created for the purpose of serving men—obedient helpers, silent supporters:

> *The woman was created to **serve man**... The scriptures state that God created woman to **serve man**.* [4]

But that's not what the Hebrew says. And it's certainly not how the Hebrew feels.

The word *EZER* does not mean servant. It means **helper**, yes—but not in a diminutive or subordinate sense.

This distinction prompts an important question: which party typically requires help, the weaker or the stronger? It is natural for the weaker party to seek assistance. And who should the weaker party look to for help? Not someone even less capable, but rather someone with greater strength or ability. This highlights the significance of the term "helper."

In fact, when we trace this word through the rest of the Old Testament, we find something astonishing: *EZER* most often refers to God Himself.

Psalm 70:5 cries out:

> *But as for me, I am poor and needy; come quickly to me, O God. You are my EZER and my deliverer; Lord, do not delay.*

This is not the language of a master calling a servant. This is a desperate soul crying for divine rescue.

Likewise, Psalm 33:20:

> *We wait in hope for the Lord; he is our EZER and our shield.*

Again and again, EZER is used to describe the one who rescues, upholds, strengthens, and saves. If EZER implies inferiority, then God is inferior to us. But of course, that is absurd. What this reveals is that a helper is not weaker—a helper is often stronger.

Strength Through Difference

Help is needed when we lack something—when we're missing perspective, wisdom, support, or strength. That's why we go to doctors, therapists, lawyers, and friends. To

call someone a "helper" is to acknowledge that we can't do it alone. It's a position of honor, not of hierarchy.

When God says Adam needs an EZER, He is not saying Adam needs an assistant. He's saying Adam is incomplete.

And what does God give? Not another man. Not a clone. But someone like Adam and yet gloriously unlike him. Flesh of his flesh, yes—but spirit with her own gifts, her own intuition, her own glory.

Women may not typically match men in brute strength, but that is only one dimension of power. Women often exceed in emotional intelligence, social perception, resilience, and intuition. In many marriages, men look to their wives not for obedience, but for wisdom. For grounding. For insight. That, too, is EZER.

No one in this world has shaped my emotional growth more deeply than my wife, Anastasia. Through her grace, patience, and wisdom, I've come to understand what it means to feel, to listen, to carry the hearts of others with care. She has been—without question—God's greatest gift to my soul. More than a companion, she is my guide, my mirror, my healer. Through her love, I've grown into the man I was always meant to become.

She was and is my greatest helper.

A Vision of Mutuality

The Bible never glorifies inequality. Though it acknowledges structure, it subverts dominance. The model for relationships—especially in the New Testament—is not command-and-control, but mutual submission.

Ephesians 5:21 says it plainly:

> *Submit to one another out of reverence for Christ.*

The passage that follows, often cited in arguments about wives submitting to husbands, begins with this command. It's not about hierarchy—it's about honor. Mutual submission. Reverent cooperation. A dance of giving, yielding, helping.

In this context, leadership is not about lordship—it's about service. Yes, every human institution ultimately needs a final authority: one president, one prime minister, one general, one CEO. Someone must carry the weight of the final word. But true greatness in leadership doesn't come from wielding power—it comes from using that authority to serve others with wisdom, humility, and responsibility.

Jesus defines authority not by power, but by sacrifice:

> *Greater love has no one than this: to lay down one's life for one's friends.*
>
> (John 15:13)

And in John 13, the Messiah wraps a towel around His waist and washes the feet of His disciples. This is what true leadership looks like.

So, if the man is to lead, let him lead like Christ. And if the woman is his EZER, let her help with strength, with grace, and with no shame.

The Divine Helper

Ultimately, EZER is not just a word for women—it's a word for God. He is our help, our rescue, our strength in weakness. And in creating woman as an EZER, God is not assigning inferiority. He is giving Adam what only God can give: a gift of wholeness.

When we call God our EZER, we are not diminishing Him—we are worshipping Him. So too, when Eve is called EZER, we must not diminish her—we must honor her.

Completing the Picture

Genesis does not say, "It is not good for man to be lonely." It says, *"It is not good for man to be alone."* There's a difference.

Loneliness is a feeling. Aloneness is a condition. God is not merely meeting Adam's emotional needs—He is completing a divine picture. Male and female, together, reflect the image of God. Neither one alone is enough.

Eve is not an afterthought. She is the culmination. The finale. The one thing in creation that causes God to say, "Very good."

Together, they are not master and servant. They are partners in purpose, co-heirs of the garden, stewards of creation. Together, they are whole.

Our Own Ezer

In our moments of weakness, fear, or failure, we cry out to God: "Help me! Save me! Be my strength!" And God answers, not from above with a shout, but from within—with presence.

He doesn't shame us for needing help. He becomes our help.

> *You are my help [EZER] and my deliverer; you are my God, do not delay.*
>
> (Psalm 40:17)

This is the heartbeat of EZER. It is the love that shows up. The strength that meets us in our lack. The presence that does not dominate, but upholds.

Let us reclaim this word. Let us honor the helpers—not as sidekicks, but as sacred reflections of God's own help.

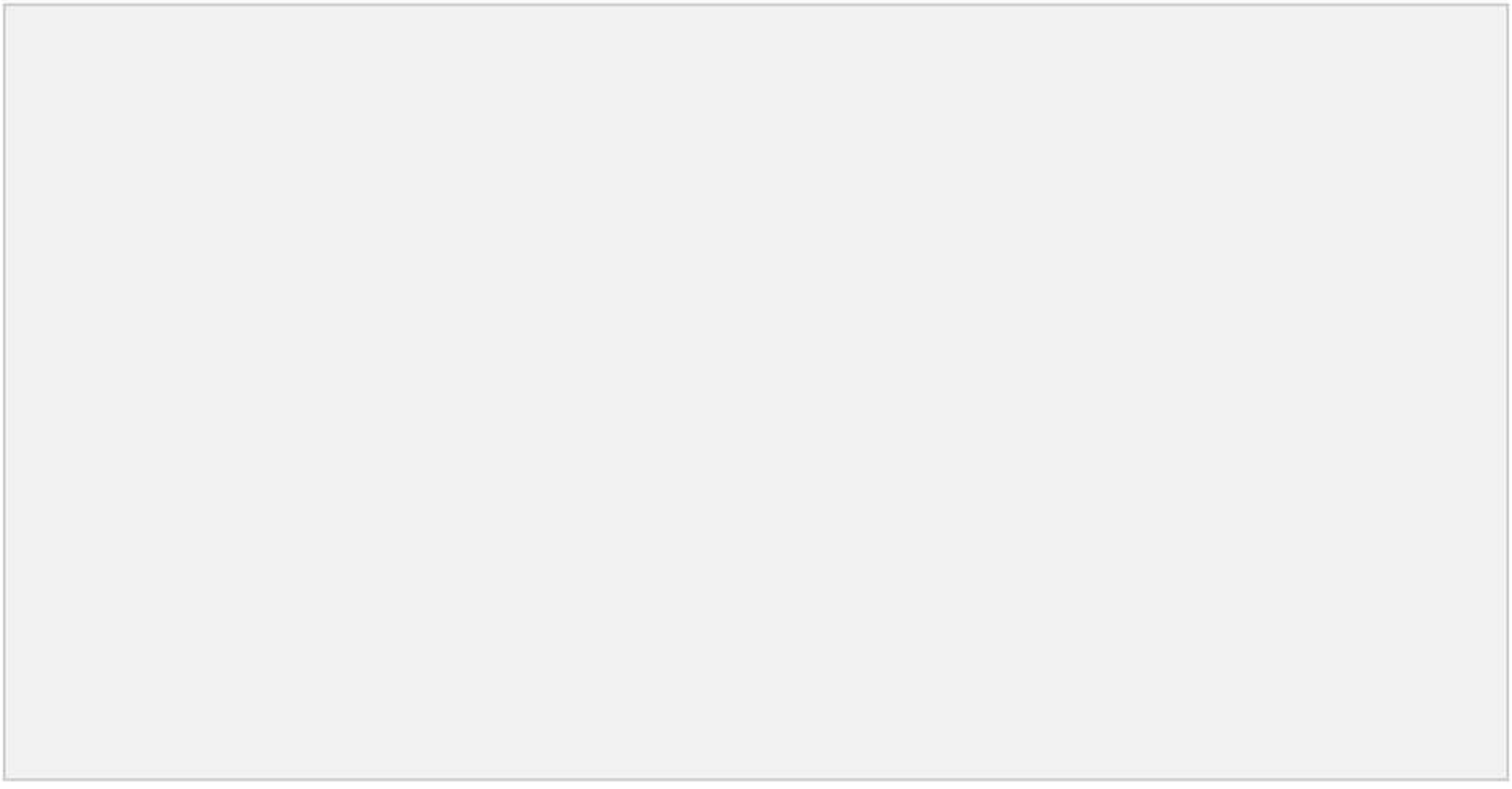
And let us be helpers ourselves—strong, wise, compassionate companions to those around us. For when we help, we do what God does. We fill what is lacking. We mend

what is broken. We bring wholeness. And that is no small thing. That is the work of God.

7

KADOSH

Holy: The God Who Comes Close



You may have heard it said: "God is too holy to look upon sin."

This idea, Calvinistic in essence, has been widely popularized in Protestant Christianity, especially in fundamentalist theological circles. Philip Ryken, a prominent voice in Reformed theology and council member of The Gospel Coalition (Calvinism's online hub), once summarized it like this:

> *God the Father could not bear to look at the sin or at His Son. He had to avert his gaze. He had to shield his eyes.* [5]

Such a claim might appear pious on the surface, but it misrepresents both the biblical text and the Hebrew understanding of holiness. The Hebrew word *KADOSH*, often translated "holy," does not primarily mean morally spotless or unable to tolerate imperfection. It means set apart, unique, or distinct.

Yes, God is without sin. But when the Bible calls God *KADOSH*, it is emphasizing His otherness and uniqueness, not a hypersensitive fragility in the face of human failure.

Holiness: More Than Moral Perfection

We tend to think of holiness as the opposite of sin. But in Hebrew thought, holiness is more like the opposite of commonness. To be holy is to be consecrated—dedicated to something higher. This applies to God, to sacred spaces, to people, and even to time, like the Sabbath:

> *Ye shall keep the sabbath therefore; for it is holy unto you.*
>
> (Exodus 31:14)

When God blesses the seventh day and makes it holy, He isn't saying the other six days are evil. He's setting it apart for a distinct purpose. The same is true for objects in the Temple—they are holy not because they are sinless, but because they are set apart for divine use.

Peter Gentry, a biblical scholar, explains *KADOSH*:

> *The basic meaning of the word is 'consecrated' or 'devoted.' In the Scripture, it operates within the context of covenant relationships and expresses commitment.* [6]

So, when we say God is holy, we don't just mean He is pure—we mean He is unlike any other. His love is different. His justice is different. His mercy, His power, His patience—all are set apart from the gods of the nations and the systems of this world.

> *For I am God, and not a man— the Holy One among you.*
>
> (Hosea 11:9)

Can a Holy God Look at Sin?

If KADOSH means God cannot be near sin, we have a theological crisis. Because sin is everywhere. And if God cannot be near sin, then He must be far from the world He created, the people He loves, and the very mission of redemption He initiated.

But Scripture tells a different story. From the beginning, God walks in the garden after Adam and Eve sin. He does not look away. He seeks them out.

In Job 1, Satan comes before God and speaks with Him. God does not avert His gaze. He engages.

In the wilderness, God dwells in the midst of sinful Israel. He doesn't float above them in contempt. He moves into their camp, into their mess:

> *The tent of meeting, which is among them in the midst of their uncleanness.*
>
> (Leviticus 16:16)

This is holiness that comes near—not holiness that withdraws.

If God were truly incapable of looking upon sin, how could He have loved or spoke with David, an adulterer and murderer? Or Moses, who killed a man in Egypt? Or Peter, who denied Jesus three times? Or Paul, who persecuted the Church?

The answer is: God's holiness is not fragile. It is transformative. Our sin doesn't hurt God. It hurts us.

Jesus: Holiness in the Flesh

The clearest revelation of God's holiness is not in His distance from sinners but in His presence among them. Jesus—the Holy One of God—did not come to condemn sinners but to sit with them, eat with them, touch them, bless them.

> *While Jesus was having dinner at Matthew's house, many tax collectors and sinners came and ate with Him and His disciples.*
> (Matthew 9:10)

If holiness means avoiding contamination, Jesus failed miserably. But if holiness means bringing something different and unique into the broken spaces of humanity, then Jesus is the perfect embodiment of KADOSH.

He did not shun sinners. He pursued them. He did not demand they clean up before approaching Him. He purified them by touch them. The God of Israel is utterly unique—because rather than condemning sinners, He clothes them in His own royal robe of honor and restoration. As Jesus illustrated in Luke 15, the father runs to the returning prodigal and dresses him not in shame, but in dignity—a robe fit for a beloved son.

Christ's uniqueness wasn't only in theory. Jesus touched the leper, embraced the outcast, healed on the Sabbath, wept with the broken. This is *KADOSH* that restores, not retreats.

And it's not only in His ministry but in His very being:

> *God made Him who had no sin to be sin for us, so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God.*
>
> (2 Corinthians 5:21)

The God Who Moves Toward the Mess

The idea that God cannot look upon sin is contradicted by the entire arc of Scripture. God doesn't avert His eyes. He rolls up His sleeves. He enters the story.

As Paul told the Athenians:

> *For in Him we live and move and have our being... We are His offspring.*
>
> (Acts 17:28)

How different is this message from the one we often hear today in the West? Consider the words of Calvinist pastor John Piper:

> It is just not true to give the impression that God doesn't hate sinners by saying, "he loves the sinner and hates the sin." He does hate sinners.[7]
>
> (John Piper)

No—God doesn't hate sinners. He loves them while they are still sinners (Romans 5:8). He doesn't withdraw from their presence—He draws near. He doesn't avoid the broken; He seeks them out. God didn't create us as immortal, all-knowing, or flawless beings like Himself. He made us fragile, limited, finite, and slow to understand. And because of that, His judgment is not cold or harsh—it is laced with mercy, rooted in the very compassion of a Creator who remembers that we are dust.

That's why the Incarnation is not a loophole in divine intolerance—it is the clearest expression of divine love.

> *Jerusalem, Jerusalem... how often I have longed to gather your children together, as a hen gathers her chicks under her wings, and you were not willing.*
>
> (Matthew 23:37)

This is holiness speaking—not with condemnation, but with compassion.

Holiness and Hospitality

In Leviticus, the term KADOSH appears nearly 100 times, and the term impurity around 130 times—yet neither is primarily associated with moral evil. Impurity was often about death, disease, or disorder. The goal wasn't to punish but to purify, to make space once again for God's dwelling among His people.

Holiness, in this sense, is like an operating room. It's not holy because it's too angry to look at germs. It's holy because it's meant to be a place of healing. If it becomes defiled, it must be cleansed—not because the surgeon is mad, but because lives are at stake.

God's presence in the Tabernacle was not fragile—it was fierce. It required purity not to exclude, but to protect. To preserve life.

And now, through Jesus, that holiness lives in us:

> *Do you not know that you are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you?*
>
> (1 Corinthians 3:16)

Reclaiming KADOSH

To say that God is too holy to look at you in your sin is to miss the entire point of holiness. Holiness is not divine disgust. It is divine distinction. It is the love that refuses to become contaminated—and yet chooses to step into the contamination to bring healing.

Jesus did not flinch from sin. He bore it.

He did not run from the cross. He embraced it.

He did not wait for us to get it right. He came while we were still sinners.

This is KADOSH. Not separation from sinners, but redemption of sinners. Not distance from darkness, but light breaking into it.

The gospel is not a story about a God who can't look at us but is doing us a favor. It's a story about a God who can't look away.

Let this be the message we preach—not a trembling God averting His eyes, but a compassionate Father running to embrace the prodigal, lifting the broken, and declaring: "Be holy, as I am holy." Not in separation—but in nearness, in love, in likeness.

He is not ashamed to be called our God.

And He is not too holy to look you in the eye.

8

SHACHAH

Worship: Even Without Music

What do you imagine when you hear the word "worship" or "worship night"? For many modern Christians, it conjures up images of dimly lit auditoriums pulsing with music, arms raised in emotive surrender, and a worship leader guiding a congregation through swelling choruses. It feels spiritual. It sounds beautiful. But is it what Scripture meant by worship? Not exactly.

In Hebrew, the word for worship is SHACHAH — to bow down, to kneel, to prostrate oneself. It's not about atmosphere or musical excellence. It's about the heart's posture. It's about a life of surrender. Worship, in its most ancient expression, was not an emotional crescendo—it was the act of laying oneself low before someone greater, and offering something costly. Indeed, you couldn't worship without making a sacrifice.

Biblical worship was always tethered to sacrifice. Praise may have been sung, but worship was enacted. You did not approach the God of Israel empty-handed. You brought your best lamb, your first fruits, your choicest oil. Worship meant something died. Worship meant something was given. Worship was not a genre; it was an offering.

A Meal for the Divine

In the ancient Near East, worshippers came to their gods with food. It was, essentially, a divine meal. The aroma of roasted meat rose from altars as a fragrant offering. This wasn't because God was hungry, but because love gives. It sacrifices. Worshipers believed that if they wanted divine protection, provision, or presence, they needed to bring something. And not just anything—something good.

We see this pattern in Genesis 4 with Cain and Abel. Abel brought *"fat portions of the firstborn of his flock"*—the ancient equivalent of grade-5 wagyu beef. Cain *"brought some of the fruits."* God was pleased with one, and not the other. The issue wasn't blood—it was quality. Abel gave the best. Cain gave leftovers. possibly some fruits or vegetables that were nearing spoilage.

This sets the tone for all future worship. It's not about the type of offering; it's about the heart behind it. To *SHACHAH* means to lower yourself and raise up something of value to God. It's bowing your pride, your time, your comfort—and offering it to someone who is worthy.

A Shift in Sacrifice

When the Temple was destroyed, animal sacrifice ceased. The Pharisees—seeing an opportunity—reimagined Jewish worship as word-based rather than deed-based. They replaced the altar with prayer. Over time, Christians, too, internalized this evolution. Worship became a matter of song and lyrics. Action was replaced with articulation.

But Jesus never abandoned the idea of sacrificial worship. He redefined it.

> *For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink... whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me.*
>
> (Matthew 25:35-40)

This is the altar of the New Covenant: not stone, but flesh. Not incense, but service. Worship is now embodied not in rituals, but in sacrificial love and relationships. It is found in the alleyways, the prisons, the shelters, and the margins.

You want to worship God? Feed the hungry. Clothe the cold. Love your enemy. That is *SHACHAH*.

Worship that Costs Something

In the New Testament, the apostles urged believers to become living sacrifices (Romans 12:1). This was not merely a metaphor. It was a call to pour out your life as Christ poured out His. Jesus didn't worship with songs. He worshiped with His body. With sweat. With tears. With blood.

To worship like Jesus is to carry your cross daily. To weep with those who weep. To give when no one is watching. To love when no one deserves it.

And this is where Western worship culture often misses the mark. We equate emotion with devotion. If the music moves us, we assume God is pleased. But worship isn't about what we feel. It's about what we offer.

> *And do not forget to do good and to share with others, for with such sacrifices God is pleased.*
>
> (Hebrews 13:16)

God is not moved by our playlists. He is moved by our compassion. He is glorified when we give our best to someone who can give us nothing in return.

Praise vs. Worship

To be clear: music is not the problem. Psalm 150 calls us to praise God with trumpet, harp, lyre, and cymbals. But praise and worship are not synonyms. Praise is an act of celebration. Worship is an act of surrender and sacrifice.

Singing songs is beautiful. But *SHACHAH* happens when we kneel before a homeless man and offer him dignity. It happens when we open our homes to the stranger. It happens when we forgive the unforgivable, love the unlovable, and give without expectation.

> *Religion that God our Father accepts as pure and faultless is this: to look after orphans and widows in their distress.*
>
> (James 1:27)

This is worship that smells like heaven. This is a fragrant offering that delights the heart of God.

Worship in Spirit and Truth

Jesus told the woman at the well that true worshipers worship in spirit and in truth (John 4:23). Spirit means no masks, no performance. Truth means alignment—our actions matching our declarations. God is not looking for theatrical displays. He's looking for authenticity. For faith that moves from heart to hand.

You can sing about justice and still ignore the poor. You can declare God's worth and still live selfishly. That is not worship. That is noise.

> *I hate your festivals; I take no delight in your solemn assemblies... But let justice roll on like a river, righteousness like a never-failing stream!*
>
> (Amos 5:21, 24)

The prophets understood what many modern believers have forgotten: God is not impressed by sacred spaces filled with empty songs. He desires hearts that bend low, hands that reach out, and lives that bleed love.

The Rebirth of Worship

Imagine a worship night where there is no stage—only a soup kitchen. No lights—only the glow of streetlamps as coats are handed to the cold. No guitar—just the sound of shared laughter and restored dignity.

This is worship. This is *SHACHAH*. Not because it lacks beauty, but because it is beauty. Not because it lacks reverence, but because it embodies reverence in the most incarnational way possible.

> *If anyone has material possessions and sees a brother or sister in need but has no pity on them, how can the love of God be in that person?*
>
> (1 John 3:17)

Worship is not a lifestyle accessory. It is a cruciform posture. It is a poured-out life.

So next time we plan a "worship night," maybe we should ask ourselves: Will this cost us anything? Will it touch the hungry, the broken, the lost? Will it bow low and lift someone else up?

Because *SHACHAH* is not about the volume of our voices—it's about the weight of our love.

Worship, in its truest form, looks like Jesus: bowed, bloodied, blessing the world:

> *Greater love has no one than this: to lay down one's life for one's friends.*
>
> (John 15:13)

9

SANE

Hate: To Avoid, Reject, and Ignore

The Hebrew word translated as "hate" is *SANE*—but it's crucial to understand that the way this word is perceived in the modern Western world is vastly different from how it functioned in biblical Hebrew. In contemporary English, "hate" is an emotionally charged word. It evokes intense feelings of hostility, disgust, loathing, or even a desire for harm. To say you "hate" someone today typically implies emotional fury, rage, or personal animosity. It's a word associated with violence, division, and often deep psychological trauma.

But in biblical Hebrew, *SANE* carries a much different, broader, more functional, and much less emotional meaning. It frequently means to reject, to avoid, to ignore, or to turn away from. In other words, hate in the Hebrew Bible is more about rejection and avoidance than anger. It's a posture of distance, not necessarily one of hostility. It describes what happens when someone or something is no longer chosen, welcomed, or drawn close—but pushed away, set aside, or left behind.

Though I'm a native Hebrew speaker and theologian, you don't have to take only my word for it—even the Ancient Hebrew Lexicon of the Bible explains *SANE* as rooted in avoidance:

> *The pictograph is a picture of a thorn, then is a picture of seed. Combined, these mean "thorn seed." The thorn, (the seed of a plant with small sharp points) causes one to turn in directions to* ***avoid*** *them.* [8]

SANE comes from the imagery of a "thorn seed," with the idea being that just as a thorn causes someone to turn aside to avoid getting pricked, to *SANE* someone is to turn aside from them—to avoid or reject.

Hate as Rejection: Election and Esau

Consider how Paul uses *SANE* in Romans 9:10–13, citing God's words in Malachi 1: *"Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated [SANE]."* In context, this isn't about God desiring Esau's demise or torment. Rather, it reflects divine election. God chose Jacob, not Esau. God

rejected *(SANE)* Esau in favor of Jacob. So in this scriptural usage, "hate" doesn't mean animosity or loathing. It means: "I did not choose him."

We also see this understanding in Paul's logic in Ephesians 5:29: *"No one ever hated their own body, but they feed and care for their body."* While modern readers may object (e.g., "I hate my enormous nose!"), Paul is working with the Hebrew concept: to *SANE* your body would be to ignore it, not to feel emotional detestation. And no one actually ignores their body—we feed it, hydrate it, clothe it. We don't *SANE* our bodies when it asks us to go to the toilet. We don't reject or abandon it.

Hate as Avoidance: Jesus' Shocking Command

This view of "hate" also sheds light on one of Jesus' most provocative statements:

> *If anyone comes to me and does not **hate** father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters—yes, even their own life—such a person cannot be my disciple.*
>
> (Luke 14:26)

To modern ears, this is unsettling. How could the Prince of Peace call us to hate our families? But Jesus, a Jewish rabbi, spoke within the framework of biblical thought. He wasn't commanding emotional hostility. He was saying: choose me over them. Be willing to walk away from them, if necessary, in order to follow me.

As a Jew, I had to walk this out. When some family members discovered I believed in Jesus, they begged me to recant. I had to choose between their expectations and Christ. I didn't "hate" them in the modern sense. I rejected their plea. That's what Jesus meant.

God Hates Sinners? The Modern Misuse of Psalm 5:5

Some influential Reformed preachers insist that Psalm 5:5–6 proves that God hates sinners:

> *You **hate** all who do wrong; you destroy those who tell lies; the bloodthirsty and deceitful you, LORD, detest.*
>
> (Psalm 5:5–6)

From this, theologians like R.C. Sproul, Tim Conway, John Piper, Mark Driscoll, and David Platt have built a disturbing theology: that God is furious with humans and abhors them until they accept Christ.

R.C. Sproul, wrote:

> We always say the Cliché, "God Hates the sin, but he loves the sinner." That's nonsense! The Bible speaks of Him abhorring us, and that we're loathsome in His sight, and He can't stand to even look at us! [9]
>
> (Pastor R.C. Sproul)

Likewise, on his YouTube sermon, *"God Hates the Sin and the Sinner,"* popular reformed pastor Tim Conway explains his views of the gospel like this:

> All of mankind are children of wrath. We are objects of the hatred of God by nature. We don't deserve His love... God is not unjust to hate mankind. Because mankind is a hateful thing by nature. It ought to be hated. [10]
>
> (Pastor Tim Conway)

Similarly, Wyatt Graham, a director of The Gospel Coalition, defines the gospel in this way:

> Jesus bore divine wrath at the cross for our sake and so protected us from it. This act implies that God hates humans since he would have poured wrath upon humans if not for the work of Christ's cross.[11]

Marco from Reading, Pennsylvania, wrote to ask reformed Baptist pastor John Piper. The question was answered by Piper in the "Ask Pastor John" podcast: *"Pastor John, what do you make of the saying, 'God loves the sinner, but hates the sin?'."* John Piper's answered:

> It is just not true to give the impression that God doesn't hate sinners by saying, "he loves the sinner and hates the sin." He does hate sinners.[12]

Piper then quoted Psalm 5:5-6 to biblically back up his claim.
Likewise, pastor Mark Driscoll preached to his congregation the same motif:

> The Bible speaks of God not just hating sin but sinners... Psalm 5:5, *"You,"* speaking of God, *"hate all evildoers."* God doesn't just hate what you do. He hates who you are![13]

And David Platt wrote:

> Does God hate sinners? Listen closely to Psalm 5:5-6: *"The arrogant cannot stand in your presence;* ***You hate all who do wrong****. You destroy those who tell lies; bloodthirsty and deceitful men the Lord abhors."*[14]

The logic of these fundamentalist preachers in quoting Psalm 5:5-6 goes something like this:

1. Those who sin are sinners.
2. Everyone sins.
3. God hates sin.
4. Therefore, God hates everyone.

But this interpretation is a complete misreading of both the language and the heart of Scripture. These preachers rely on English translations and anachronistic interpretations. They fail to understand what *SANE* truly means.

The Broader Context of Psalm 5

Mitchell Dahood, a leading Hebraist scholar, says Psalm 5 is about *"repudiation of false gods when one was accused of idolatry."*[15] Similarly, VanGemeren, Professor Emeritus of Old Testament and Semitic Languages, explains that Psalm 5 is about God distinguishing Himself from pagan deities (who embody both good and evil):

> Whereas other religions brought together good and evil at the level of the gods, God had revealed that evil exists apart from him.[16]

So, with this context in mind, more accurate than "God hates us all" will be to say that God hates-ignores idol worshippers.

Thus, when Psalm 5 says, *"You hate all who do wrong,"* it doesn't mean God emotionally loathes all sinners. It means He rejects idolatrous and evil behavior. In context, these "evildoers" are not merely people who sin occasionally. They are those who worship false gods and commit atrocities like child sacrifice.

It is not a hatred of humanity. It is a rejection of wicked systems, cultures, and spiritual rebellion.

SANE: The Absence of Blessings, Not the Presence of Rage

SANE is best understood like darkness or cold. Darkness isn't a substance—it's the absence of light. Cold isn't a thing—it's the absence of heat. Likewise, hate in the Hebrew sense is the absence of connection, blessings, affection, and relational engagement.

This is why anger and hate are not the same. When you love someone, you get angry at their self-destruction. You argue. You grieve. You intervene. But when you hate someone—biblically—you go quiet. You avoid. You let go.

The woman who hates her husband isn't the one yelling; she's the one who packed her bags and left without a word. She's disengaged.

God Avoids Evil But Still Loves Sinners

If *SANE* is rejection, avoidance, and the withholding of blessings, then when Scripture says God "hates" evildoers, it means He turns away from their destructive ways. He withdraws His covering. He resists them. But this does not mean He stops loving them.

Jesus was God in flesh. And what did He do? He touched the unclean. He dined with sinners. He forgave prostitutes. He wept over murderers.

If God "hates" sinners in the Sproul, Piper, and other Calvinists claim, then Jesus wasn't God. But He is God. And He loved sinners.

> God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us.
>
> (Romans 5:8)

> Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners—of whom I am the worst.

(1 Timothy 1:15)

Paul says God loved him while he was a sinner. So if God hates all sinners in the way fundamentalists preach, Paul should have never been saved.

God Is Love, Not Rage

This misunderstanding reveals a tragic distortion in much of modern fundamentalism: portraying God not as a loving Father, but as a raging tyrant.

But God is not wrath. God is not rage. God is love (1 John 4:8). And yes, He disciplines. Yes, He judges. But His aim is always redemption, never retribution for its own sake. God is no sadist. He withholds blessings from the wicked to call them back to Himself, not to smash them out of disgust.

Likewise, His Son didn't tell us to loathe our enemies. He said:

> *Love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you, that you may be children of your Father in heaven.*
>
> (Matthew 5:44–45)

Children imitate their Father. And if we are to love enemies, that's because our Father loves enemies, too.

In conclusion, the word *SANE* does not mean to be filled with contempt or rage. It means to reject. To turn away. To avoid. And when God "hates," it is not because He is unloving, but because He is love. He cannot participate in evil, and so He distances Himself from it.

But never confuse distance for indifference. God still longs for every sinner. He is not loathing them; He is longing for them. Consider Jesus' Parable of the Prodigal Son, especially verse 20:

"So he got up and went to his father. But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son, threw his arms around him and kissed him." (Luke 15:20)

The son is making his way home and his father spots him, not when the son is steps away from the estate but while he is still a significant distance off. Remarkably, it wasn't a servant who noticed the returning figure and informed the father; the father himself saw. I can imagine in my mind how the father would rise every morning at 4:45 a.m., prepare meals, and journey for an hour to the closest mountain. After reaching the summit, he would position himself for the best possible view. Perhaps he even set up camp there, resolved not to descend until his son's return. Numerous possibilities clouded the father's thoughts: had his son perished, or had he found a different life elsewhere? Yet the father's unwavering gaze betrayed his hope. Deep within, he believed his son would come back.

Eitan Bar, "God as Father"

Much like our Father in heaven, the prodigal's father didn't hate his son when he stubbornly lived in sin—he longed to see him.

Our Father doesn't punch sinners in the face. He dies for them.

He doesn't hate the world. He so loved it.

So let us reject the abusive doctrine that says God abhors people. Let us return to the Hebrew heart of Scripture and reclaim a God who loves, a Savior who embraces, and a Spirit who draws near—not because we are perfect, but because He is.

That's the gospel. That's grace. That's SANE redefined.

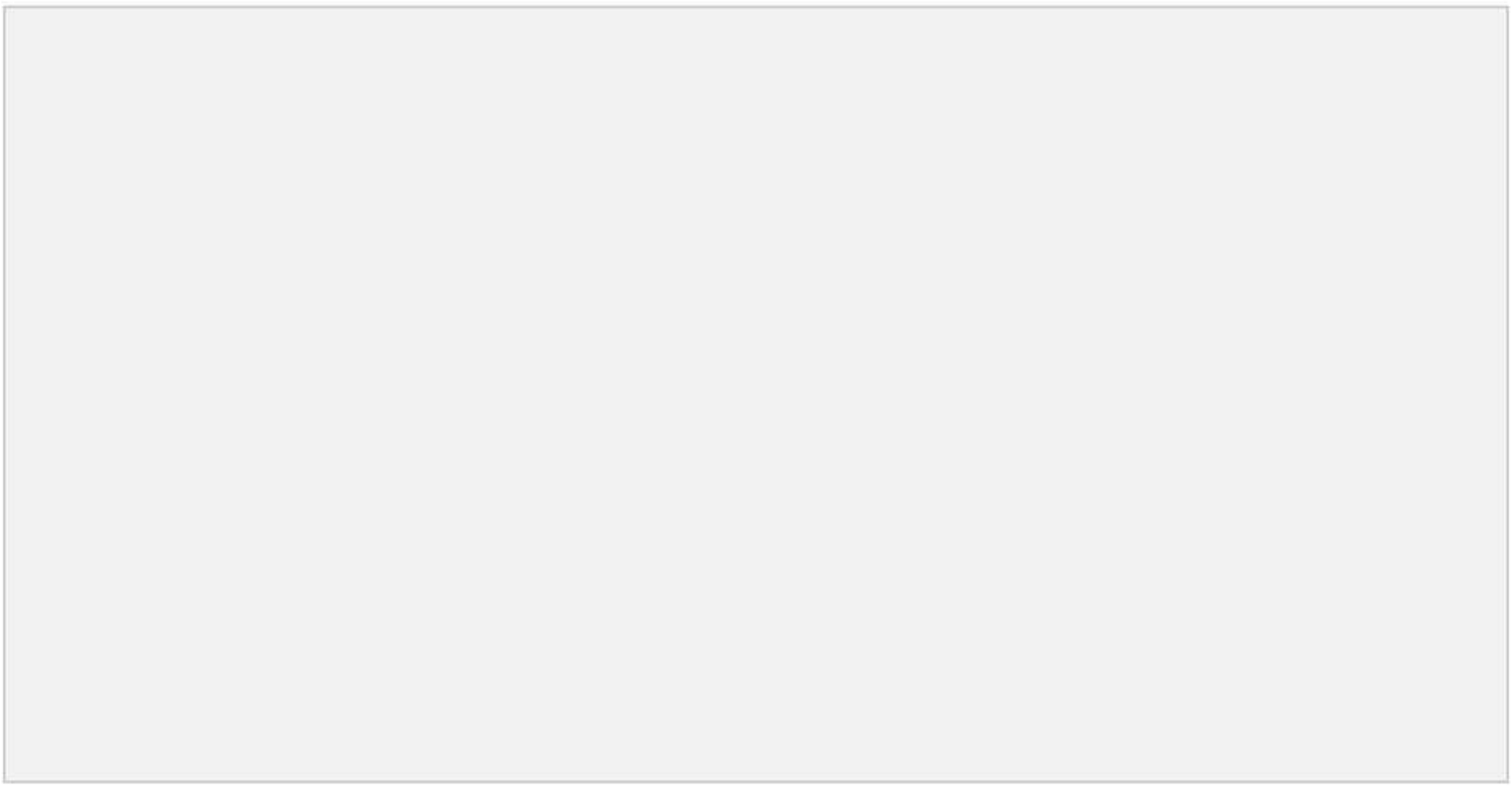
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If you struggle to see God as your loving Father or to understand His love for sinners, I invite you to read my short book, ***"God as Father: Unveiling God's Love for Sinners, Outcasts, Legalists and Jerks Through the Prodigal Son."***

10

NAQAM

The Vengeance That Heals



In modern Western culture, the word vengeance drips with the bitter taste of rage and retaliation. We imagine revenge through cinematic lenses—gritty anti-heroes, blood-stained justice, explosive battles for payback. To exact vengeance is to settle the score. It's emotional. Brutal. Personal. Yet when Scripture speaks of vengeance, particularly in Hebrew, it invites us into a very different imagination—one not driven by ego, pain, or rage, but by restorative justice and the long arc of divine mercy.

The Hebrew word *NAQAM*, often translated as "vengeance," defies the shallowness of our revenge fantasies. It means more than retaliation—it implies setting things right, a divine act rooted not in wrathful punishment but in faithful covenantal justice. The root idea of *NAQAM* is not about destruction, but about corrective rebalancing, bringing equilibrium where evil and injustice have tipped the scales.

Human Vengeance vs. Divine Justice

When humans seek vengeance, we are often led by bruised egos or unresolved pain. Revenge is rarely about justice—it's about feeling better. We lash out, not to restore wholeness, but to satisfy our wounded pride. Consider how nations go to war, families break apart, reputations are destroyed—all under the pretense of "justice," when in truth, it's pain begging to be seen.

God's vengeance is not like this.

Scripture is replete with a radically different vision of divine vengeance. The wrath of God is not chaotic fury—it is focused, purposeful, and redemptive. It is justice that heals. Consider Isaiah 61:2:

> *To proclaim the year of the LORD's favor and the day of **vengeance** of our God, to **comfort** all who mourn…*

Did you catch that?

God's day of vengeance and comfort are spoken in the same breath. The vengeance of God isn't for entertainment or ego—it's to comfort the mourners. It's not to destroy sinners but to deliver the brokenhearted from what sin has done to the world.

Vengeance is not God's wild rage—it's His passionate justice rushing in to rescue what evil tried to destroy.

Let God Be the Judge

Paul echoes this divine logic in Romans 12:19:

> *Do not take revenge, my dear friends, but leave room for God's wrath, for it is written: "It is mine to avenge; I will repay," says the Lord.*

Why does Paul tell us to stand back and leave room for God? Not because God's payback will be harsher, but because His vengeance serves a purpose we can't accomplish—restoration.

Human vengeance only knows how to punish. Divine vengeance knows how to purify. We judge from pain. God judges from love.

This idea is beautifully expressed in Isaiah 1:24–26:

> *Ah! I will vent my **wrath** on my foes… I will thoroughly purge away your dross… I will **restore** your leaders as in days of old… Afterward, you will be called the City of **Righteousness**.*

God's vengeance leads to purification. God's wrath, in its truest biblical sense, is like a fire that refines, not a wildfire that destroys. It's discipline that purges away impurity. It is judgment that leads to redemption.

God's Justice Is Not Man's Retaliation

The Hebrew prophets constantly remind us: God's judgment is aimed at renewal. Even

His most dramatic acts of wrath—like the plagues in Egypt—were designed not for destruction but for repentance.

Yes, the Nile turned to blood. Yes, Egypt trembled under judgment.

But through these signs, hearts were stirred. Egyptians (not just Israelites) joined the Exodus (Exodus 12:38). God's "vengeance" created the cracks in Pharaoh's empire so that the light of deliverance could break through—for all who would believe.

Vengeance, then, was not an explosion of divine fury. It was an invitation to salvation.

Just as the plagues brought Egypt to its knees, the judgments in Revelation invite the nations to turn and be healed. Even at the end of history, God's acts of justice are still filled with the mercy of one last call: Come home.

God's Vengeance vs. Our Revenge

To retaliate is carnal. To forgive is divine.

When we try to take justice into our own hands, we only perpetuate the pain. The one who hits back only guarantees the next blow. But when we choose mercy, when we surrender vengeance, we create space for God to step in—not just to deal with the wrongdoer, but to transform both of us.

> *Bless those who persecute you... Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.*
>
> (Romans 12:14, 21)

We are not called to be agents of divine punishment. We are called to be agents of divine reflection. When we forgive those who hurt us, we mirror God's redemptive heart. Forgiveness is not pretending the wrong didn't happen. It's saying: "I will not be the one to repay. I will not let your sin turn me into something I'm not."

Jesus, the embodiment of divine justice, did not cry for revenge from the cross. He said, *"Father, forgive them."*

Restorative Judgment

A good judge in a healthy society doesn't hand out punishments to feel better. A good judge discerns truth, weighs circumstances, and seeks justice that leads to restoration. In God's economy, vengeance is never the final word. Redemption is.

"I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked," says the Lord in Ezekiel 33:11, *"but rather that they turn from their ways and live."*

Even divine wrath has this longing built into it—not to destroy, but to awaken. Not to shame, but to heal. God reveals the sin not to humiliate the sinner, but to expose the wound so it can finally be healed.

A Love That Judges

When people say "God is love," they often mean it in a soft, harmless way. But love that never says "No," never disciplines, never corrects—is not love at all. Love must judge. Love must speak. Love must protect.

Divine judgment is what happens when God's love collides with human injustice. It is not the opposite of grace—it is grace in action. And *NAQAM* is the justice of God flowing from a heart that refuses to let evil have the last word.

When Jesus cleared the temple courts, it wasn't wrath divorced from love. It was love that had reached its breaking point with injustice. He turned over tables not to destroy but to cleanse. His *NAQAM* wasn't an eruption of temper—it was a purification of sacred space.

And in the grandest expression of divine vengeance, Jesus took upon Himself the full weight of sin—not to crush the world, but to redeem it. He bore justice to give us mercy. He absorbed wrath to unleash grace.

What Does This Mean for Us?

To live in the spirit of *NAQAM* is to resist retaliation and entrust justice to God.

It means...

Speaking truth without becoming bitter. Seeking justice without losing mercy. Refusing to repay evil with evil. Trusting God to deal with those who hurt us—even when it takes longer than we'd like.

Most of all, it means living in such a way that our response to wrong doesn't mirror the world's instinct for vengeance but reflects God's instinct for redemption.

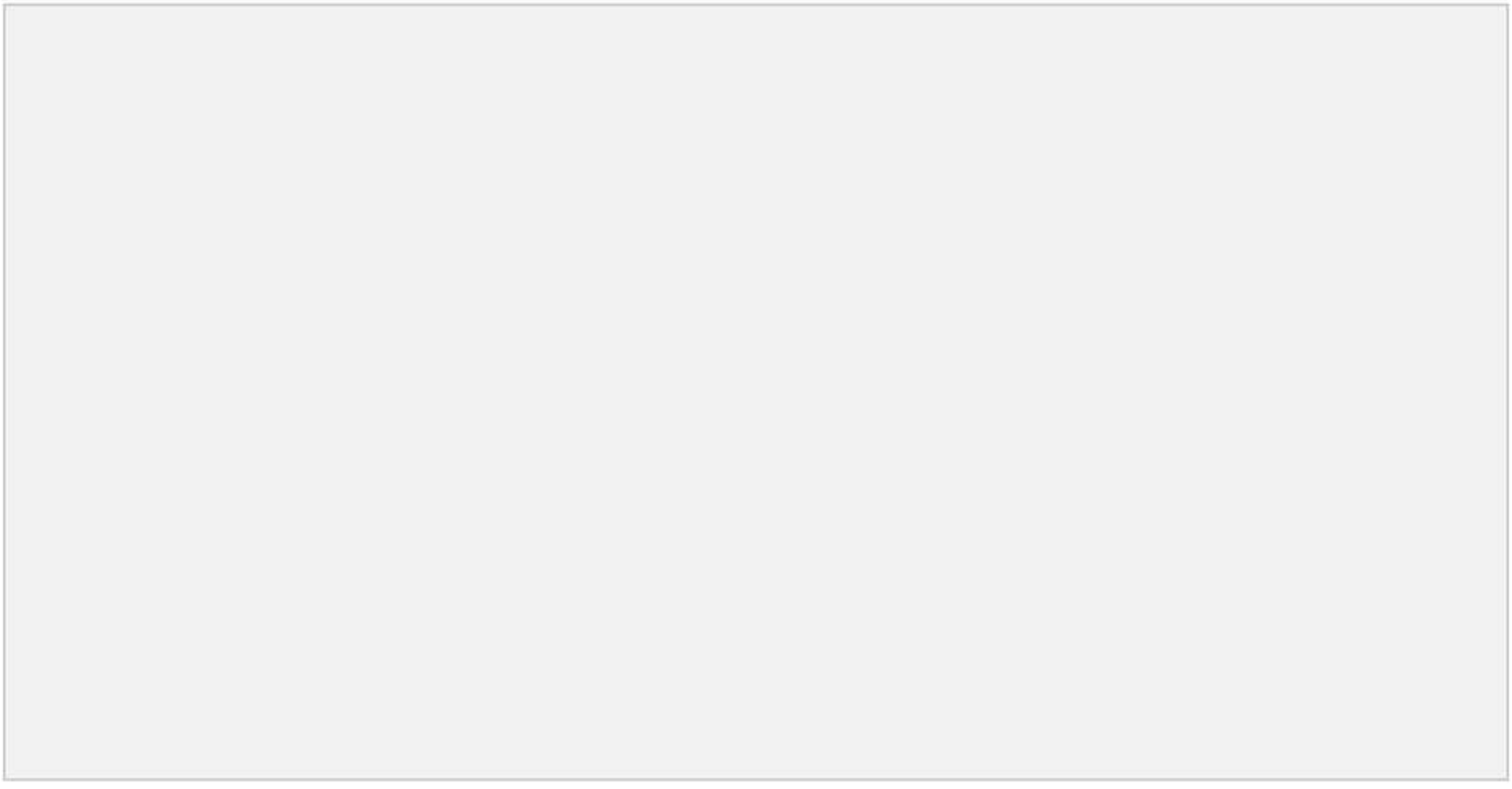
"Vengeance is mine," says the Lord. Not because He's angrier than us—but because He's wiser, purer, and more committed to saving the world than we'll ever be.

So when someone wounds you, don't strike back. Pray. When you are wronged, don't retaliate. Forgive. When you are mistreated, don't plot revenge. Let go. Let God be God.

11

SHEVET

The ROD That Guides, Not Strikes



Among the most widely misinterpreted and dangerously weaponized verses in the Bible is Proverbs 13:24:

> *Whoever spares the **rod [SHEVET]** hates their children, but the one who loves their children is careful to discipline them.*

For many, this verse has been misread not as parental wisdom, but as a divine endorsement of corporal punishment. In the hands of some religious teachers, the "rod" (*SHEVET* in Hebrew) has become a license for cruelty.

No book illustrates this distortion more tragically than the best-seller *To Train Up a Child* by Baptist preacher Michael Pearl and his wife Debi. Selling over a million copies and translated into dozens of languages, it teaches parents to "discipline" children with belts, plastic tubing, whips, switches, and even cold showers and food deprivation. According to the Pearls, spanking, whipping, and "breaking the child's will" are signs of biblical love. In their own words:

> *A spanking (whipping, paddling, switching, or belting) is indispensable to the removal of guilt in your child. His very conscience (nature) demands punishment.*
>
> Page 46

This theology of fear and pain is based, in large part, on a single word: *SHEVET*—"the rod." But the Pearls' interpretation of this word, and of God's character, is not only biblically misguided—it's spiritually toxic and, in too many tragic cases, deadly. Several children have died from abusive parenting inspired by this book. Others have grown up damaged, angry, afraid, or worse—convinced that love looks like pain and discipline feels like fear.

But what if *SHEVET* never meant to strike?

The Rod of the Shepherd

The word *SHEVET* in Hebrew is rich with meaning. It does not refer to a weapon of violence—it refers to a shepherd's staff.

Israel was, and still is, a land of shepherds. Even today, you can drive through modern, high-tech Israel and see Bedouins herding sheep along highways. A shepherd's rod was never designed for beating the sheep. It was a tool of guidance, defense, and authority. It served three main purposes:

Protection: To drive away predators.

Direction: To gently block a sheep from wandering.

Inspection: To count and examine the sheep, ensuring their health.

The shepherd's rod is not a symbol of punishment—it is a symbol of presence, of care, of authority rooted in love.

This is why David, Israel's most famous shepherd, wrote:

> *Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod [SHEVET] and your staff, they comfort me.*
>
> (Psalm 23:4)

Comfort. Not fear. Not bruises. Not broken wills.

David's *SHEVET* brought security, not suffering. Because in Hebrew imagination, discipline was never about crushing—it was about leading, correcting, protecting.

Lost in Translation: When "Rod" Became "Rage"

So how did *SHEVET* become a justification for abuse?

As is often the case, it starts with translation—not just of language, but of worldview.

The Western world inherited a theological lens shaped more by Roman punishment and Calvinist guilt than by Hebraic covenantal love. In that lens, discipline became synonymous with pain. Authority became dominance. And the image of a shepherd's rod morphed into an instrument of wrath.

Combine that with a penal-substitution understanding of the gospel—where God, the angry Father, must pour out His wrath on His Son to appease His justice—and it's not hard to see how earthly fathers began to believe that love means pain, that physical punishment is redemptive, that God "beats" His children into submission.

But this is not the God of Scripture.

This is not the Jesus who took children into His arms and blessed them, who said, "Let the little children come to me."

The problem is not with Proverbs 13—it's with the interpretive framework of divine abuse.

Irony and Tragedy: The Rod Turned Against the Sheep

The Shepherd does not beat up the sheep with his rod and does not cause them distress. If panicked, they will only run away and freak out the rest. Sheep are to be disciplined with extra tenderness and gentleness, not by hurting them with whips, belts, plastic tubes, a switch, or rods.

The only time a shepherd would ever use his rod to strike was in defense—to fend off wolves or thieves. Tragically, the Pearls and others have turned the rod not on the predators, but on the sheep themselves.

This reversal is not just tragic—it's demonic.

Children are not wolves to be beaten; they are lambs to be led. A child's spirit is soft and moldable, not something to be "broken" like a wild horse. Love does not bruise—it builds. Discipline does not injure—it instructs.

When a child is harmed in the name of God, it is God's name that is defamed, not honored.

When Rods Become Weapons: Real Lives, Real Damage

For 20 years, I lived within a fundamentalist movement in Israel called "Messianic Judaism." And I witnessed the cost of this ideology firsthand.

One family, devout and sincere, used the Pearls' methods faithfully. Their three sons were “trained up” according to the book—flogged, isolated, “broken.” Today, one is dead by suicide. Another is in prison. The third was homeless, addicted, and lost. Then he died.

Another pastor I knew beat his children to force “obedience.” Today, both sons are drug addicts, unable to hold jobs or relationships. The son of one Messianic-Baptist pastor, following lifelong of physical abuse at home, beat his wife to death in 2023. And yet the father still believes he was acting in love—just as God the Father did on the cross.

These are not outliers. These are the fruits of theology gone mad. Where the cross is seen as a crime of divine violence instead of an act of self-giving love, parenting becomes fear-based. Children grow up scared of mistakes, terrified of punishment, and detached from grace.

Proverbs 13:24 – What Does the Bible Actually Say?

Let’s revisit Proverbs 13:24 in its original context:

> *Whoever spares the rod hates their children, but the one who loves their children is careful to discipline them.*

Notice the second half: careful to discipline them. This is not rage. This is not reaction. This is not abuse. It is attentiveness, wisdom, consistency. Care is the operative word, not corporal.

Likewise, Proverbs 22:6 says:

Train up a child in the way they should go, and when they are old, they will not depart from it.

"Train" here is not coerce, but dedicate. Create pathways, shape character, build trust. Not through fear and pain, but through faithfulness.

And when Jesus came, He didn't whip children into shape. He blessed them. He lifted them up as the model of the kingdom. *"Unless you become like one of these…"* (Matthew 18:3)

The Real Meaning of Discipline

The word "discipline" shares its root with "disciple." To discipline is to teach, not to terrorize. It is to help a child become someone they were meant to be—not to punish them into compliance but to train them in love.

Good discipline teaches responsibility, not fear. It guides the child toward maturity, not submission. It creates safety, not silence.

SHEVET as Rule, Not Rod

In Psalm 2, the Messiah is said to *"rule the nations with a rod of iron."* Again, the image is *SHEVET*—but not a bludgeon. It's an image of unshakable authority, of leadership that cannot be corrupted. Iron, unlike wood, was seen as unbreakable. It's the rod of justice, not the stick of punishment.

In Revelation 12, the Messiah born from Israel is to *"rule with a rod of iron."* But the Greek word used is *poimainō*—to shepherd. This rod is not a club. It is a shepherd's staff, an image of righteous leadership and unyielding protection.

The rod was never about pain. It was always about presence.

Healing the Wounds of Divine Abuse

Many who grow up in fear-based homes—where love was confused with control, and discipline with domination—spend their lives spiritually limping. They either run from God entirely or stay trapped in performance-based religion, constantly trying to earn love or avoid punishment.

But the gospel offers a better Father.

One who does not strike His children, but guides them. One who does not punish out of anger, but disciplines out of mercy. One who does not break wills, but mends hearts.

Shepherd, Not Slave Master

Research into the lives of serial killers and abusers—particularly their family histories—has led to a sobering conclusion: one of the most effective ways to cultivate criminal behavior is through hyper-legalistic parenting that wounds both the body and the soul. When discipline becomes domination and rules replace relationship, the damage can run deep—and often, tragically, turn violent.

The way we understand our Father in heaven – to be loving, tender, and full of compassion or angry, furious, and hateful – will directly reflect on how we raise our children. Whether we like it or not, our theology shapes everything about us, including how we treat others. If people look at the cross and see the violence of a Father abusing and killing his own Son, we should not be surprised if they, too, justify their abusive behavior towards their children under the banner of "godly discipline," fearing if they won't hit them hard enough, God will.

Biblical *SHEVET* is not for beating your child into shape. It's for leading them into life.

God is not an abusive Father who loves by hurting. He is a Good Shepherd who leads us beside still waters and restores our soul. His rod does not bruise—it comforts.

If your theology tells you to hit your children to make them good, then your theology is fear-driven.

To truly train up a child is to walk with them, not whip them. To correct them in love, not crush them with power. To give them the same mercy God gave you.

Let us rediscover the meaning of *SHEVET*—and use our hands not to hurt, but to heal.

12

GE-HINNOM (GEHENNA)

"Hell"

You very likely heard the claim that "Jesus talked more about hell than He did about heaven." Take, for example, the words of famous Calvinist Pastor John MacArthur:

> Yes, Jesus was a Hellfire preacher... Jesus spoke more about hell than anybody else in the Bible. In fact, He spoke more about hell than everybody else in the Bible combined.... He continually spoke about hell and He warned sinners to escape hell because of its horrible reality.[17]
>
> The gospels and the writers of the New Testament describe hell as a fiery place, and its fire is the fire of torture and torment. It's also described as darkness, outer darkness, like being lost in the most infinite corner of space under horrible torture and pain, a place of weeping, wailing, teeth-grinding agony.[18]
>
> John MacArthur

This statement, however, is incorrect. In fact, Jesus not once spoke of "hell" but spoke of *GE-HINNOM* (or *GEHENNA in* Greek) a term or metaphor well-known in Judaism.

The term "Gehenna," used by Jesus in the New Testament as a metaphor to describe the condition of suffering and divine consequences, was understood by Jews of the first and second centuries primarily as symbolizing harsh consequences rather than a destination in the afterlife.

In Matthew 23:15, Jesus condemns the religious leaders for making their converts *"twice as much a child of hell"* as themselves. Here, Jesus uses "hell" (*GEHENNA*) as a present reality rather than a future destination, suggesting that He viewed *GEHENNA* as a condition of moral, spiritual, physical, mental, or emotional corruption occurring in this life. This indicates that Jesus understood *GEHENNA* as an earthly state of separation from God's ways and its consequences, characterized by hypocrisy and spiritual blindness, rather than an eternal place of torment awaiting sinners in the afterlife.

This interpretation aligns with the views of early Jewish and Christian thinkers, including Saint Origen. Origen, a Church Father from the second century, engaged extensively with Jewish scholars and writings, which influenced his understanding of

scriptural texts. In his work '*Against Celsus*,' Origen discusses *GEHENNA*, suggesting that Jews who did use it in terms of afterlife reality in his time viewed it more as a temporary process or place intended for purification and correction rather than eternal damnation.

Origin was a prolific writer who wrote roughly 2,000 treatises in multiple branches of theology, including textual criticism, biblical exegesis, hermeneutics, and homiletics. He was one of the most influential and controversial figures in early Christian theology and apologetics. He has been described as *"the greatest genius the early church ever produced."*[19]

Origen wrote extensively about the New Testament gospels and his interactions with Jews, but the most pertinent section is as follows:

> Now as we found that Gehenna was mentioned in the Gospel as a place of punishment, we searched to see whether it is mentioned anywhere in the ancient Scriptures, and especially because the Jews too use the word. And we ascertained that where the valley of the son of Ennom was named in Scripture in the Hebrew, instead of valley, with fundamentally the same meaning, it was termed both the valley of Ennom and also Gehenna. And continuing our researches, we find that what was termed Gehenna, or the valley of Ennom, was included in the lot of the tribe of Benjamin, in which Jerusalem also was situated. And seeking to ascertain what might be the inference from the heavenly Jerusalem belonging to the lot of Benjamin and the valley of Ennom, we find a certain confirmation of what is said regarding the place of punishment, **intended for the purification of such souls as are to be purified** by torments, agreeably to the saying: *"The Lord comes like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: and He shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver and of gold."*
>
> Origen, Against Celsus, VI, 25.

This context is crucial for interpreting New Testament references to *GEHENNA*, as it underscores the idea that early interpretations of this term, even when using it as

an afterlife concept, might have leaned towards a temporary, corrective punishment rather than an unending torment.

Valley of Hinnom

Gehenna comes from the Hebrew phrase "*GE-HINNOM*," which means the "valley of wailing." It's an actual valley, here in Israel, on the southwest side of Jerusalem (Joshua 15:8).

In that valley, in the gorge known as *Topheth*, worshipers performed child sacrifices in the fire (2 Kings 23:10). This site was dedicated to the god Molech, to whom Israel's kings like Ahaz and Manasseh sacrificed their children (2 Chronicles 28:1-3; 2 Chronicles 33:6). The prophets confronted this evil, saying that God would send enemy nations to conquer Jerusalem, and Israel's leaders would be killed and their dead bodies thrown into that valley to be burned (Jeremiah 7:30-33). The fires that those kings started to consume the innocent would one day turn and consume them. While Israel experienced many purifying fires from God for their sins (e.g., Isaiah 1:25, 48:10, Jeremiah 9:7, Malachi 3:2-3, Zechariah 13:9.), the act of burning young children as offerings to pagan idols was the most abhorrent of them all.

In ancient Israel, *GEHENNA* was essentially synonymous with **shame** and **disgrace**, representing a dark and ignominious chapter in Israel's history that led to significant purifying judgment. For example, Jeremiah said that this place would become "the valley of slaughter," for in that ditch, the Babylonians would dump the corpses of the Israelites:

> *So beware, the days are coming, declares the Lord, when people will no longer call this place Topheth or the Valley of Ben Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter.*
>
> Jeremiah 19:6

In later Jewish literature, such as 1 Enoch, which predates the New Testament, the Valley of Hinnom symbolized Israel's purifying punishments. God frequently punished

Israel, but the biblical punishments were always for the sake of correction; otherwise, Israel would have long ceased to exist. God's punishment is real, but it is not akin to Augustine's or Calvin's understanding of punishment as sadistic and never ending.

Jesus, also a prophet of Israel, used these same images of 'fire' and 'Gehenna' to describe horrible evils and shame and God's response to them. God promised He wouldn't let evil go unchecked (Isaiah 13:11, Nahum 1:3, Proverbs 11:21, Jeremiah 25:31, Ezekiel 18:30, Malachi 4:1). Therefore, the fire of God's justice will ultimately consume all evil and remove it from His beloved nation. Likewise, He will purify His creation once and for all (Revelation 21:1-4; 2 Peter 3:3-9).

This Jewish term symbolizing shame and punishment, Gehenna, occurs 12 times in the New Testament and is often translated as "hell," misunderstood by many modern readers as an afterlife endless torturous destination.

The Valley of Unpleasant Odors

The Kidron Valley, now a national park in Jerusalem, encompasses the Valley of Hinnom, also known as Gehenna, within its borders.[20]

The presence of urban garbage dumps, where city residents would burn waste, is widely recognized, although their exact locations have been unclear and debatable. To ensure you are well-informed of the ongoing heated debate, primarily between Calvinists and non-Calvinists, regarding Hellfire and whether Hinnom was a garbage dump, consider the following: In 2011, Francis Chan, a Calvinist pastor, authored "*Erasing Hell,*" aiming to disprove the garbage dump theory. Subsequently, in 2015, DL Kennedy penned "*Gehenna Revisited: Rebutting Francis Chan*," which sought to counter Chan's claims.

A Jerusalem excavation has confirmed the existence of a substantial city garbage dump in the Kidron area:

> The chance discovery of an Early Roman city dump (1st century CE) in Jerusalem has yielded for the first time ever quantitative data on garbage components that introduce us to the mundane daily life Jerusalemites led and the kind of animals that were featured

> in their diet. Most of the garbage consists of pottery shards, all common tableware, while prestige objects are entirely absent. Other significant garbage components include numerous fragments of cooking ovens, wall plaster, animal bones and plant remains. Of the pottery vessels, cooking pots are the most abundant type. Most of the refuse turns out to be "household garbage" originating in the domestic areas of the city...[21]

Likewise, Rabbi David Kimhi (1160–1235), in his commentary on Psalms 27:13, noted that fires were perpetually maintained in the valley of Hinnom to consume the waste and corpses deposited there. Likewise, the Jewish Talmud links the location with fire and smoke (Erovin 19).

As with all city dumps, the poor, including lepers, often scavenged through the garbage. The waste and refuse that accumulated were often incinerated to be disposed of. Since there was always someone throwing their trash in this worms' paradise, the fires never ceased.

Quoting Isaiah 66:24, Jesus reminded his audience that:

> *Gehenna, where "the worms that eat them do not die, and the fire is not quenched."*
>
> Mark 9:47-48

Worms do die; however, the metaphorical notion that they never perish is possibly linked to the abundant, continuous "food" (either corpses, garbage, or both) they consume. This could represent the numerous individuals who perished and were cast into the valley at various times in history, both before and after Christ's time.

The central issue is not whether the Valley of Hinnom served as the city's refuse site or merely as a location for discarding dead bodies (as mentioned in Jeremiah 7:31-32, 9:6-7, 19:11-12, and Isaiah 30:33). The significance lies in its symbolism of Israel's disgraceful past and the dire consequences that followed.

Jesus' summoning of Isaiah 66:24 likely evoked memories in the Jewish consciousness of Isaiah and Jeremiah's descriptions of numerous corpses thrown into the Valley of Hinnom during the Babylonian siege.

Jesus wasn't trying to describe some horrific afterlife cosmic scenario but was referring to a place well-known to Jews. A place symbolizing shame, humiliation, degradation, and divine consequences on Israel when failing to walk in God's ways. It was a way for Jesus to warn the nation of Israel of the upcoming repercussions of their failure to repent and change their ways.

Theologian Edward William Fudge, explains:

> The term conveyed a sense of total horror and disgust…Gehenna was a place of undying worm and irresistible fire, an abhorrent place where crawling maggots and smoldering heat raced each other to consume the putrefying fare served them each day. [22]

Unfortunately, Jesus' caution to Israel became a reality. The first-century historian Josephus documents that, during the Roman siege of Jerusalem, corpses were thrown over the city walls into the adjacent valleys due to the lack of burial space within the city (Jos. War 5.12.3).

Clearly, to first-century Jews, Gehenna was a tangible location infamous for its disgustingness, repulsiveness, and revulsion. It was emblematic of shame and humiliation, accompanied by images of fire, refuse, and death. It was the same national warning as before, only this time coming from the Prophet of prophets.

To Be Thrown Into Gehenna (Matthew 5:27-29)

Let's examine Matthew 5:27-29 as a case study:

> *You have heard that it was said, "You shall not commit adultery." But I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart. If your right eye causes you*

> *to stumble, gouge it out and throw it away. It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to be thrown into Gehenna.*
>
> Matthew 5:27-29

Interestingly, those who read the "Gehenna" as a literal description of the afterlife often read "gouge your eye out" as a metaphor.

However, if we take seriously the statement that Jesus *"did not say anything to them without using a parable"* (Matthew 13:34), then we must reconsider the Augustinian-Calvinistic interpretation of hellfire.

So, what did Jesus mean when he said that men looking at a woman with lust will end up in Gehenna? Was Jesus really promoting self-mutilation and teaching—as some believe—that looking at a woman lustfully will result in eternal punishment in Hellfire?

It's hard for me to imagine that Jesus, who only a few verses earlier said, *"Do not think that I have come to abolish Law or the Prophets"* (5:17), would contradict both Himself and Moses in suggesting eternal Hellfire torment for anyone lusting in their mind, a concept utterly foreign to the Law and to Jews.

Clearly, Rabbi Jesus, a master of using parables, symbolism, and metaphors to convey deeper spiritual truths, was speaking figuratively. Otherwise, if we interpret Jesus' words in Matthew 5:29 about plucking out one's eye literally, we face an ethical and theological contradiction, as it seems unimaginable that Jesus would advocate for self-mutilation.

In his commentary on Matthew, theologian Francis Wright Beare points to the challenges in giving a literal interpretation to these words of Jesus:

> If this [Mt. 5:29-30] is to be taken as a 'demand' of Jesus, then it must be said that he is demanding the impossible, for it is the universal experience that the sexual impulses are uncontrollable.[23]
>
> Francis Wright Beare

It is improbable that Jesus was saying that if you were sexually aroused by looking at another person or fantasizing about them, even momentarily, you'd literally end up tortured in Hellfire forever. Jesus likely had children and teenagers—such as his disciples—in his audience.[24] Was he teaching them to literally dismember body parts, like their eyes, to ensure they would be saved from eternal torture in fire? If so, didn't Jesus know we don't need eyes to imagine and fantasize?

People who become blind are still capable of lusting in their minds. Would Jesus actually instruct these young men that they would be eternally punished just for having sexual thoughts? Considering that sexual thoughts are a common human experience, why would God design us with these impulses and then imply eternal torture for entertaining them? How could that be considered just? A literal interpretation of Jesus's hyperbolic metaphors in Matthew 5 is nonsensical and misrepresents God's character, yet it does explain some of the religious legalism observed in the world.

Jesus often used hyperbolic language—a common rhetorical technique in Jewish teachings—to emphasize that evil begins with our thoughts. The use of such vivid metaphors was not to instill a fear of eternal damnation for typical human experiences like sexual thoughts, but to stress the ethical life choices expected in his teachings. Lust was merely an example of something much bigger. Recognizing that lust is a common human experience his audience would relate to, Jesus highlighted the need for accountability and the pursuit of a higher moral standard, which Israel often failed to uphold. Jesus, knowing that probably all of his listeners lust in their minds, used it to make a point. Remember, Jesus wasn't speaking to a specific individual. His audience was a *"crowd of Jews"* (verse 1); he was a Prophet addressing the nation of Israel.

Why Threaten With Gehenna?

Suppose you were judged and condemned by society and, therefore, had to scavenge for leftovers in Gehenna to survive; it meant you got to the lowest point in your life—a place of great shame. You've likely lost everything and become an outcast.

When all New Testament texts using Gehenna are considered,[25] things become even more apparent. Jesus symbolically uses Gehenna to teach about consequences.

Imagine the kind of shame people who lived in or scavenged through Gehenna Valley felt—constant shame and embarrassment. For that reason, missing one eye is better "*than to have two eyes and be thrown into the fire of Gehenna*" (Matthew 18:9). Losing a body part is preferable to scavenging for food amidst Gehenna's trash and flames for the rest of your life.

If you were an Israelite caught committing adultery, you would either be stoned or become an outcast of society and find yourself living in shame in a dumpster—Gehenna. New Testament scholar N.T. Wright explains:

> When Jesus was warning his hearers about Gehenna, he was not, as a general rule, telling them that unless they repented in this life, they would burn in the next one. As with God's kingdom, so with its opposite: it is on earth that things matter, not somewhere else.[26]
>
> N.T. Wright

Every act of adultery ever committed started with a lustful thought, but not all lustful thoughts led to adultery. Harboring lustful thoughts might lead to dire consequences, as thoughts can manifest into actions. In a rigid religious society, such as that of second-temple Judaism, certain actions may provoke severe repercussions, stripping you of all you hold dear and casting you out to scavenge in the city's dump—Gehenna—as no one is willing to hire or work with you.

God's Gehenna is Restorative

The ability to control one's thoughts is essential, but there's an even deeper lesson to be learned. It was not God who threw individuals into the Valley of Hinnom; it was the people—a hyper-religious society. While God desires that even sinners live with dignity, be rebuilt, and become self-sufficient, it is religious leaders who often cancel, boycott, degrade, and essentially lead sinners into the Valley of Shame.

In contrast, when God witnesses sinners committing adultery, He does not seek to shame or abandon them. How do I know? Well, because when religious people

brought a woman caught in adultery before Christ, suggesting she needed to be severely punished, Jesus did the very opposite of what the religious leaders hoped for. He forgave her: "*Then neither do I condemn you,*" Jesus declared. "*Go now and leave your life of sin.*" (John 8:11). She did indeed sin. But Jesus did not condemn her. The religious legalists did.

Even if everything I have said so far is false... Even if Gehenna were to be taken literally as an afterlife cosmic fire chamber that endlessly burns people, this interpretation clashes with biblical prophecies. Jeremiah proclaims that one day Gehenna "*will be holy to the Lord*" (Jeremiah 31:40), while the Psalmist envisions it transformed into a place where *"thirsty hearts journey to appear before God in Zion, the valley of Gehenna will become a place of springs"* (Psalm 84:5-7). These passages suggest a restoration and sanctification of Gehenna, not its perpetuation as a place of eternal torment. How, then, could Gehenna be a literal and unending Hellfire if it is destined to become holy and rejuvenated? These Old Testament prophecies seem to directly contradict the idea of Gehenna as a place of eternal suffering, as conceived by adherents of the ECT Hellfire doctrine.

Conclusion

To conclude, in Jewish thought, Gehenna symbolized the severe consequences of straying from God's path. On a national level, this concept represented the tangible loss of divine blessings and protection. On an individual level, it represented the outcome of sin, especially in an unforgiving religious society. As a result, those who deviated faced vulnerability and adversity, akin to being left to fend for themselves in a desolate wasteland. Jesus used Gehenna both as a reminder and a threat for Israel —Your enemies will consume you, and you will be left to scavenge in the ruins.

Akin to the prophets of Israel before him, Jesus issued a direct warning to Israel: Turn away from your evil ways, or you will once again be consumed by Gehenna's flames, scavenging through the ashes to survive. His admonition to Israel was a tangible threat. This prophecy's fulfillment began 40 years later, starting in 70 AD, after a relentless five-month siege, with the Romans razing Jerusalem and the Second Temple. Rome decimated Jerusalem, killing and reducing the people of Israel to starvation amidst the ruins. According to first-century historian Josephus, over one

million people, mostly Jews, were killed during the siege, with many corpses thrown into Gehenna.[27]

13

YIR'AH

The Reverence and Awe of God

Have you ever ascended to the summit of the Eiffel Tower or stood at the prow of a boat amidst the vast ocean? Maybe you've perched on the edge of a mountain cliff or lain under a star-studded sky in the desert. If you have, you might remember the deep sense of awe, reverence, and sheer wonder that enveloped you. Undoubtedly, even the most courageous adventurer standing at the edge of an Olympic springboard would be hard-pressed to keep their heart from trembling. All of these feelings could be best described as *YIR'AH*.

Old Testament Fear

While some English translations choose the English word "fear" to translate *YIR'AH*, other translations use "Awe," [28] "Respect," [29] and "Reverence." [30]

Moses was overcome with *YIR'AH* when he pleaded with God to witness His glory (Exodus 33). Similarly, the Israelites were steeped in *YIR'AH* when Moses descended from Mount Sinai with a shining face (Exodus 34).

YIR'AH most often relates to experiencing something that surpasses one's abilities and comprehension.

To the modern eye, the concept of "fearing God" may initially appear to imply being scared, terrified, or afraid of God, but this isn't the biblical meaning. *YIR'AH* of God encapsulates a sense of awe, respect, and reverence toward God's majesty. You only want to study something—or someone—thoughtfully when you are in awe of them.

YIR'AH is an acknowledgment of God's sovereignty over all things, being all-powerful, etc. In the Old Testament, a Hebrew root with multiple meanings—Y-R-A—conveys different ideas depending on the context. *YARE* & *YIR'AH* are examples of Hebrew words derived from this root, meaning reverence, respect, or awe. In Genesis 22:12, it is used to describe Abraham's respect and trust in God:

> *"Do not lay a hand on the boy," he said. "Do not do anything to him. Now I know that you YIR'AH God, because you have not withheld from me your son, your only son."*
>
> Genesis 22:12

In Proverbs 1:7, *YIR'AH* is used to describe wisdom and knowledge:

> *The fear of (YIRAT) the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; but fools despise wisdom and instruction.*
>
> Proverbs 1:7

In this Proverb, the contrast of knowledge is despising wisdom and instruction, while the contrast of *YIR'AH* is a foolish person. If *YIR'AH* were about being scared-terrified, then the opposite would not be a foolish person who despises wisdom but fearlessness. In this context, having *YIR'AH* —or being impressed with God—is the opposite of a fool: someone who rejects wisdom and instruction.

For illustration's sake, imagine a master craftsman and an apprentice. The apprentice must approach the master with respect and a willingness to learn, recognizing the master's expertise and authority. If the apprentice despises the master's instruction, they are unlikely to gain the skills and knowledge needed to become a craftsman themselves. *YIR'AH*, in this case, represents the apprentice's awe and respect for the master, which is essential for true learning. In contrast, a fool is like an apprentice who rejects the master's wisdom, thereby missing the opportunity to grow and develop.

The Hebrew words in the Hebrew Scriptures that describe what we in modern language consider "fear" are *EIMAH* (terror) and *PACHAD* (scare). These are when you are afraid for your life, fearing someone will want to hurt you or kill you. However, the words used in Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 are different, meaning "awe" or "reverence." In other words, wisdom begins with awe and respect for God, not with fearing he'll kill you…

In the New Testament, when Paul delivered his sermon in the synagogue at Antioch, he addressed two distinct groups: *"Men of Israel and **you who fear God**, listen"* (Acts 13:16). "God-fearers" is a known phrase meant to describe Gentiles who demonstrated deep respect and reverence for the God of Israel. In the Book of Acts, *"God-fearing Gentiles"* (Acts 13:26) refers to Gentiles (non-Jews) who were attracted to Judaism and the God of Israel but had not fully converted to Judaism.

Paul didn't refer in his sermon to people who were scared-terrified of the God of Israel. On the contrary, they were drawn to Him because they were in awe

and respected Him. They admired the God of Israel's power, justice, and goodness. Their "fear" was not one that repels but one that attracts and motivates obedience, encourages humility and fosters a more profound, respectful relationship with God.

New Testament Fear

Luke 12:5 (Matthew 10:28)

> *Meanwhile, when a crowd of many thousands had gathered, so that they were trampling on one another, Jesus began to speak first to his disciples, saying:* ***"Be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy.*** *2 There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known. 3 What you have said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have whispered in the ear in the inner rooms will be proclaimed from the roofs." 4 "I tell you, my friends, do not be afraid of those who kill the body and after that can do no more. 5 But I will show you whom you should fear:* ***Fear him who, after your body has been killed, has authority to throw you into hell [Gehenna].*** *Yes, I tell you,* ***fear him****. 6 Are not five sparrows sold for two pennies? Yet not one of them is forgotten by God. 7 Indeed, the very hairs of your head are all numbered.* ***Don't be afraid****; you are worth more than many sparrows.*
>
> Luke 12:1-7

If you've been around the hell discussion long enough, you may have heard some advocates of the Augusinian-Calvinist hellfire explain that it's not really God who will send you to hellfire or torture you forever but Satan and his demons or that God doesn't cast anyone to hell because we send ourselves there. However, these same people also often cite Luke 12, contradictingly arguing for the necessity to fear God, who allegedly may throw you into the fire to consume your flesh forever for misdeeds.

Luke 12:5, along with Matthew 10:28, has been a subject of intense debate among devout Christians. Some English Bible translations reflect that view well:

> *But I will warn you whom to fear: fear the **One** who, after **He** has killed, has the power to throw that person into hell; yes, I tell you, fear **Him**!*
>
> NASB

Notice that "One," "Him," and "He" are capitalized, indicating the translator's theological belief that these words speak of God. The NLV takes it a step further, explicitly using the word "God":

However, many other translations, including the King James, ASV and NIV, have refrained from interpreting the verse, instead adhering to the original Greek text. For instance:

> *But I will forewarn you whom ye shall fear: Fear **him**, which after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear **him**.*
>
> KJV

The meaning of the Greek word *τὸν (ton)* means "to/he/the" (definite article). As you can see, some translations have decided to translate the word "τὸν" in Luke 12:5 as God, while most others have kept it neutral.

The word *μετά (meta)* in verse 5, often translated as "after," can also be translated as "also" or "not only." In that case, the audience is to fear X, who can destroy not only their body but also their soul.

Context

Understanding any verse in the Bible necessitates considering its context. Luke 12 is embedded within a broader dialogue where Jesus discusses matters of the heart. In

this segment, the focus is on being wise (12:1) while not being fearful (12:4,7).

The verse in question is part of a passage where Jesus exhorts his followers not to fear their persecutors. Subsequently, Jesus reassures his disciples not to live in fear (12:6-7), emphasizing God's care for them. It seems illogical and contradictory to suggest that Jesus, having devoted this teaching to the theme of not being afraid, would simultaneously instill cosmic fear in his young Jewish disciples. In verses 22-32, Jesus reiterates again his teaching not to fear, emphasizing God's care for them.

What if Jesus Did Speak of God?

For the sake of argument, let's assume Jesus was speaking not of Satan or some human authority like a priest, judge, or Roman officials—as some theologians believe—but of God. How, then, can we understand Luke 12:1-7?

Luke 12 begins with Jesus's warning against the *"leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy."* (12:1). Here, Jesus is warning against the sin of religious hypocrisy. Hypocrisy involves living a double life. On the outside, you exhibit a façade of righteousness and judge others according to religious standards you yourself don't live up to, but behind closed doors, you are filled with evil. That's why Jesus called the Pharisees *"whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside but on the inside are full of the bones of the dead and everything unclean"* (Matthew 23:27).

In Judaism, shame is regarded as equally detrimental as death, if not more so (Bava Metzia 59a). Given that Gehenna-hell was an actual geographical location historically associated with shame and repletes with repulsive waste incinerated in fire and worms-consuming remnants—also symbolizing profound shame—it can be construed as a cautionary tale that God might expose religious hypocrisy, potentially leading individuals to a life of shame.

Long story short, you may be able to fool people but not God, who can and will expose your hypocrisy if you fail to repent. And when He does, society may turn you into an outcast. This is precisely the warning Jesus gives in verse 2:

> *There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known. What you have said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have whispered in the ear in the inner rooms will be proclaimed from the roofs.*
>
> Luke 12:2-3

Luke 12 can be seen as a caution against the sin of hypocrisy, which has the potential to ruin one's soul and lead to being an outcast—scavenging for leftovers in the valley of Gehenna. Sin's influence extends beyond mere physical death; it can corrupt the soul and will lead to a life of destruction.

At the national level, this was precisely Israel's fate. The religious leaders of Israel failed to turn away from their hypocrisy, resulting in the devastation of Jerusalem and the temple (70 AD), followed by exile. Consequently, numerous Jews faced poverty and homelessness, forced to forage for sustenance, enduring what could be described as a literal hell.

Fear and Trembling?

Another loved verse by fear-driven fundamentalists is Philippians 2:12:

> *Therefore, my dear friends, as you have always obeyed—not only in my presence, but now much more in my absence—continue to work out your salvation with* ***fear and trembling****.*
>
> Philippians 2:12, NIV

John Bertram Phillips, most noted for his The New Testament in Modern English, wrote:

I had for some time been worried about the expression "fear and trembling." It did not seem likely to me that Paul in writing to the Philippians could have meant literally that they were to work out their salvation in a condition of anxiety and nervousness. We all know that fear destroys love and spoils relationships, and a great deal of the New Testament is taken up with getting rid of the old ideas of fear and substituting the new ideas of love and trust. I realized that the Greek word translated 'fear' can equally well mean 'reverence' or 'awe' or even 'respect,' but I was bothered about the 'trembling.' Surely the same Spirit who inspired Paul to write to Timothy that 'God has not given us the spirit of fear; but of power and of love and of a sound mind' could not also have meant us to live our entire lives in a state of nervous terror.... When Paul wrote to the Corinthians and reported that Titus had been encouraged and refreshed by their reception of him, he then went on to say that the Corinthian Christians received him with 'fear and trembling'! (2 Cor. 7:15) Now, this makes no sense unless it is a purely conventional verbal form implying proper respect. [31]

14

EMUNAH

Faith That's Active

In the Hebrew language, the ideas of "belief," "trust," and "faith" are not separated as they often are in English theological discourse. They are unified through a single linguistic root: A-M-N. From this root come the words:

EMUNAH: Faith

EMUN: Trust

AMEN: A declaration of trust, belief, or affirmation

So when a Hebrew speaker ends a prayer with "Amen," they are not merely saying "the end" or "so be it." They are saying, "I trust," or "I affirm this to be true." This interconnectedness shapes how native Hebrew speakers understand faith. To have *EMUNAH* in someone or something is to both believe it to be true and to actively trust it with one's life.

This is why in both ancient and modern Hebrew thought, *EMUNAH* is not a static intellectual concept. It is a lived posture. You don't merely think faith; you walk it, breathe it, embody it. *EMUNAH* means relational trust that manifests in action.

To illustrate, consider how we speak of trust in ordinary life. A coach places *EMUNAH* in a player by assigning them as captain. An employee entrusts a coworker with a key project. A patient trusts a doctor with their life in surgery. In each case, belief and trust become concrete decisions based on a relational reality. Biblical *EMUNAH* works the same way.

Faith in the Jewish Tradition

During the time of Jesus and the Second Temple period, *EMUNAH* was commonly exercised in the rabbinic world. Jewish disciples didn't follow rabbis because of a systematic theology or because of a sinner's prayer. They followed rabbis because they believed in them—they had *EMUNAH* that this rabbi could guide them to live a righteous life in covenant with God which will lead to divine blessings.

To have *EMUNAH* in a rabbi was to say: "I will walk in your way because I trust your path leads to truth." It was never just about eternity or salvation. It was about living rightly today. The rabbi was a role model to imitate.

This same relational dynamic is seen between Abraham and God. Genesis 15:6 says:

> *Abram had EMUNAH in the LORD, and He credited it to him as righteousness.*

Abraham's faith was not a belief in abstract doctrines but a relational trust in the God who promised him a future. His *EMUNAH* made him righteous not because he passed a theological test, but because he surrendered his story to God's story.

Faith as Trust, Not Intellectual Proof

In modern Western Christianity, faith is often presented as intellectual belief—affirming theological propositions as true. This model can be traced back to the Reformation emphasis on "faith alone" (sola fide), which, while important, has sometimes been flattened into mere mental assent. But biblical *EMUNAH* is thicker than this. It's not about agreeing with a creed; it's about trusting the Creator with your very breath.

This is why Paul quotes Habakkuk in Romans 1:17:

> *The righteous shall live by EMUNAH.*

Habakkuk 2:4 says:

> *The righteous person will live by his EMUNAH.*

This doesn't mean that people are saved merely because they agree with a doctrinal checklist presented to them from a leaflet. It means that they live out their relationship with God in faithful trust, even when they don't understand the full picture.

The Role of Faith in Salvation

Many Christians assume that Judaism teaches salvation through works, while Christianity teaches salvation through faith. This is a false dichotomy. Many Jews believe that their place in the covenant and in the world to come was secured by God's loving grace. Their works were not to earn salvation but to live a blessed life and to honor the covenant. As the Mishnah (Sanhedrin 10:1) says: *"All of Israel has a share in the World to Come—even the sinners of Israel."*

What mattered was being part of the covenant community and remaining faithful. When John the Baptist and Jesus called Israel to repentance, it wasn't because they thought works saved. It was because national repentance was required to avoid national catastrophe—namely, the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple, which occurred in 70 AD.

Faith in Jesus as Messiah (Yeshua) was thus a continuation and climax of this Jewish *EMUNAH* tradition. To say, "I believe in Jesus" meant: "I entrust myself to this Rabbi, this Son of David, this Anointed One, who embodies God's salvation."

Faith That Grows

Faith is not binary. It grows, shifts, bends, and reforms. Peter's faith was a roller coaster. One day he said, *"You are the Christ,"* and the next day he denied knowing Jesus. Yet Jesus never disowned him. Instead, He reinstated him:

"Go tell my brothers to meet me in Galilee." (Matthew 28:10)

Jesus still called them "brothers," even after they deserted Him. This is *EMUNAH* from God's side. He is faithful even when we are not. As Paul writes:

> *If we are not faithful, He remains faithful, for He cannot deny Himself.*
>
> (2 Timothy 2:13)

EMUNAH, then, is not about having perfect faith. It's about holding onto the one who is perfectly faithful. It's not about never doubting. It's about returning after you do.

EMUNAH and the Covenant Relationship

In Hebrew thought, *EMUNAH* is not merely intellectual assent but a covenantal loyalty. This isn't just believing in God like you believe in gravity—it's trusting Him with your life, aligning yourself to His heart, His ways, and His promises. In the same way a spouse remains loyal not only through romantic affection but through fidelity, commitment, and endurance, so *EMUNAH* calls us to respond to God not with sporadic belief but with lifelong allegiance.

In the Old Testament, covenantal language saturates God's relationship with His people. When He called Israel His "bride," He was expressing a relationship founded not just on law but on faithfulness—on mutual *EMUNAH*. He was loyal to them, even when they weren't. And in response, He desired a people whose trust in Him wasn't merely theological, but deeply relational.

This is why, when Israel abandoned God for idols, it wasn't described merely as "bad behavior" but as "adultery." The prophets don't accuse Israel of breaking rules—they accuse her of breaking trust (*EMUN*).

> *"Return, faithless Israel," declares the Lord, "I will not look on you in anger. For I am merciful," declares the Lord; "I will not be angry forever."*
>
> (Jeremiah 3:12)

God longed not simply for religious observance but for renewed *EMUNAH*—a return to trust, to fidelity, to intimacy.

In this sense, faith is not merely about believing certain doctrines are true. It's about giving your heart. It's a relational word. And this changes how we understand both faith and doubt.

Faith and Doubt Can Coexist

Western Christians are often taught to fear doubt—as if faith must be unwavering or else it is invalid. But in Scripture, we often see faith and doubt intertwined. Peter had *EMUNAH* when he stepped out of the boat to walk on water—and yet, he began to sink. Did Jesus disown him for doubting? No. He reached out and saved him.

Faith and doubt are not opposites. In fact, doubt is sometimes the soil in which true *EMUNAH* takes deep root.

Think of a child learning to ride a bike. The first few times are terrifying. They might not fully believe they can do it, but they trust their parent enough to try. *EMUNAH* often works the same way. It's not about the absence of fear; it's about moving forward in the presence of it—because you trust the one calling you forward.

This is why Jesus said faith the size of a mustard seed is enough to move a mountain. Because *EMUNAH* isn't about magnitude—it's about direction. It's about placing your trust—even weakly, even uncertainly—in the one who is faithful.

> *If we are faithless, he remains faithful— for he cannot deny himself.*
>
> (2 Timothy 2:13)

The Faith of Jesus

In Christian theology, we often speak of "faith in Jesus." But the New Testament also speaks of the "faith of Jesus." In Greek, the phrase *pistis Christou* can be translated either as "faith in Christ" or "the faithfulness of Christ." Both are true.

Jesus had *EMUNAH* too.

He trusted His Father—even unto death. In Gethsemane, He wrestled with fear and anguish, even asking for the cup to pass. And yet, He entrusted Himself to the Father's will. This was *EMUNAH* in its purest form: not cheerful optimism, but courageous trust in the face of suffering.

This means that our salvation doesn't merely depend on our ability to have perfect faith—it depends on the perfect faithfulness of Jesus. And that's good news. Because even when our *EMUNAH* falters, His does not.

> *Let us fix our eyes on Jesus, the author and perfecter of our faith…*
>
> (Hebrews 12:2)

Faith Expresses Itself in Action

Some readers might ask: but doesn't the Bible say that faith without works is dead?

Yes, it does. But this doesn't mean our works save us. Only God saves. It means that real *EMUNAH*—like real love—manifests in visible ways. When you trust someone, your actions will reflect that trust. If I say I trust my doctor but ignore her instructions, my trust is empty. If I say I trust a bridge but refuse to walk across it, my *EMUNAH* is theoretical.

James, who wrote *"faith without works is dead"* (James 2:17), was arguing against a hollow faith—a faith that lives in the head but never reaches the hands.

Real EMUNAH leads to transformation. It opens the heart. It gives. It forgives. It obeys. It loves sacrificially. Not out of fear of punishment, but out of trust in the One who is good.

This is why Paul can say both, *"We are saved by grace through faith, not by works"* (Ephesians 2:8–9), and *"faith works through love"* (Galatians 5:6).

Faith is not opposed to action. Faith is what gives action its meaning.

Faith and Faithfulness

In Hebrew, *EMUNAH* is not just belief—it is fidelity. God is the one who never gives up, never lets go, never walks away. He is faithful even when we are not. He keeps His promises. He pursues us when we run. He builds us up when we fall apart. And He forgives seventy times seven.

Faith in the Bible is not merely what we believe. It's who we trust. And ultimately, it's who we become.

As we grow in *EMUNAH*, we become more faithful. More trustworthy. More like God.

EMUNAH also invites us to rest.

Many religious people live in anxiety—unsure if they've done enough, prayed enough, believed enough. But *EMUNAH* says: trust Him. He will not let you go. His grip is stronger than yours. Your salvation is not held up by your performance, but by His promise.

> *Come to me, all who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.*
>
> (Matthew 11:28)

This is the rest of *EMUNAH*. Not a lazy kind of rest, but a soul-deep confidence in the faithfulness of God. You are safe in His hands. You don't need to climb to heaven; heaven has come to you. You don't need to prove your worth; your worth was proven at the cross.

You can breathe. You can rest. You can rejoice. You are His. And He is faithful.

15

APHAR

DUST: What We're Made Of

*For dust you are, and to **dust [APHAR]** you shall return.*

(Genesis 3:19)

This verse, uttered in the Garden of Eden as part of humanity's curse, might be one of the most haunting—and humbling—lines in all of Scripture. But what is it really saying? Why dust? Why not something grander like stone—durable and strong? Why not earth or clay, which are richer and more cohesive materials? Why does God deliberately remind us that we are, quite literally, dust?

The Hebrew word used here is *APHAR*, and its implications run far deeper than a mere poetic reference to death. In the biblical imagination, dust is a theological mirror, revealing something fundamental about what it means to be human.

Dust as a Symbol of Fragility

Dust is not cohesive like soil or clay. It is what remains when everything else has broken down. It is the most transient and weightless of materials—easily swept up by the wind, trampled underfoot, and scattered without consequence.

The Bible frequently uses dust to symbolize human frailty and humility:

Job says, *"I am reduced to dust and ashes."* (Job 30:19)

Abraham says to God, *"I am but dust and ashes."* (Genesis 18:27)

Ecclesiastes reminds us, *"All go to the same place; all come from dust, and to dust all return."* (Ecclesiastes 3:20)

To be dust is to be breakable. It is to be small. It is to be mortal. It's a sobering image, especially in a world that prizes strength, success, and self-sufficiency. Scripture confronts us with a hard truth: despite our technology, wealth, and power, we are still dust.

The Breath in the Dust

But the story doesn't stop there. Just a chapter before the curse in Genesis 3, there is

a moment of holy transformation:

> *Then the Lord God formed the man from the dust [APHAR] of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life, and the man became a living being.*
>
> (Genesis 2:7)

Dust, when infused with the breath of God, becomes animated. It becomes human. This juxtaposition—dust and divine breath—is the core tension of our existence. On one hand, we are lowly and finite. On the other, we carry within us something Divine.

We are not gods. But we are dust touched by God.

The message is clear: without God's breath, we are nothing. But with His breath, we are capable of life, love, purpose, and even eternity.

Dust vs. Earth: A Contrast in Substance

Hebrew makes a subtle but profound distinction between two seemingly similar words: *APHAR* (dust) and *ADAMAH* (earth/soil). Earth is fertile and full of potential—it is the raw material of creation. Dust, on the other hand, represents what remains after life has faded.

It's no accident that the name Adam is drawn from *ADAMAH*, linking humanity to the fertile earth. We are formed from the same material that brings forth life. Yet when Adam sins, the judgment is that he will return not to *ADAMAH*, but to *APHAR*.

This reveals a powerful contrast: Earth symbolizes potential, creativity, and flourishing. Dust represents disintegration, loss, and mortality.

And yet, there's beauty in this contrast. For God, even dust is not the end.

Dust and Divine Compassion

Throughout Scripture, dust is not only a symbol of human frailty—it is also a trigger

for divine compassion.

> *For He knows how we are formed, He remembers that we are dust.*
>
> (Psalm 103:14)

God doesn't despise us for our fragility. He remembers it. He knows our frame. He takes our weaknesses into account. He doesn't demand perfection from dust. Instead, He meets it with grace.

To be dust is to live within limitations. But God does not abandon us there. The whole narrative of Scripture—from Eden to Calvary to the New Jerusalem—is a story of dust being renewed, reclaimed, and resurrected.

Dust and Repentance

In ancient Israelite culture, to cover oneself with dust or ashes was a sign of grief, humility, and repentance. Job repents in *"dust and ashes."* Mordecai sits in ashes when he hears of the king's decree to kill the Jews. This isn't because dust has magical properties—it's symbolic.

To sit in dust is to say: *"I lower myself. I recognize my need for mercy."*

Jesus echoed this symbol when rebuking unrepentant cities: *"If the miracles that were performed in you had been performed in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes."* (Matthew 11:21)

Ashes and dust are where humans meet the reality of their condition—and open themselves to transformation.

Dust as a Beginning, Not the End

When Genesis says, *"to dust you shall return,"* it is not pronouncing a cosmic death sentence. It is acknowledging a cycle. A rhythm of life, death, and new life again.

Jesus affirmed this very principle when He described His own death using the metaphor of a seed falling into the earth:

> *Unless a kernel of wheat falls to the ground and dies, it remains alone.*
> *But if it dies, it produces many seeds.*
>
> (John 12:24)

In death, the body returns to dust. But in the hands of the Creator, dust is not discarded. It is reformed. It becomes seedbed for something new. The apostle Paul reminds believers of this promise in 1 Corinthians 15, where he speaks of the resurrection body being raised from the perishable—yes, from the dust.

In many Christian traditions, Ash Wednesday marks the beginning of Lent—a season of reflection and repentance. On that day, believers receive ashes on their foreheads, often with the words: "Remember that you are dust, and to dust you shall return."

It is not meant to depress—it is meant to awaken.

It reminds us of our mortality, yes. But it also invites us to live well, to turn back to God, and to remember that even dust is held in His hands.

To be made of dust is not an insult—it is a sacred paradox. We are humble, mortal, fleeting—and yet beloved, breathed into by God, and destined for renewal.

Dust is not where our story ends. It is where grace begins.

God took dust and made Adam. God took scattered dust and made Israel a people. God takes our brokenness—the dry, dusty places of our lives—and breathes new life into them:

> *He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the ash heap.*
>
> (Psalm 113:7)

Even dust has a future when held in the hands of God.

A Small Request

We may not agree on every little detail — and that is fine — but I hope you found my "Jewish perspective" convincing, or at least informative and uplifting. Before you close this book (or switch off your e-reader), I have a small yet important favor to ask. I have invested a considerable amount of time and effort into writing this book (and as a native Hebrew speaker, I accomplished this in a language that is not my own). Therefore, if this book blessed you in any way, please consider expressing your appreciation by sparing a few seconds to rate it on Amazon and Goodreads. If you also have two minutes to spare, leaving a short review would also mean the world to me. As an indie-author, I make it a point to read each and every review.

If you want to go the extra mile, feel free to post about the book on social media or even get copies for friends—It's a beautiful gift!

Finally, there are additional books covering a range of spiritual and biblical subjects that you can find on my Amazon page. Furthermore, you can explore a few hundred articles on my website, **www.eitan.bar —** I invite you to take a look at both!

TODA *(Thank you)* and blessings from Israel,

Dr. Eitan Bar

Endnotes

1. For example, Revelation 19:15, "Coming out of his mouth is a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations," is frequently referenced, out of context, to imply a violent return of Jesus. I invite you to explore the Book of Revelation within its original Jewish context in my book ***"Revelation: A Jewish Perspective."***

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3. William K. Gilders, Sacrifice in Ancient IsraelVisited December 2022.

4. Ivory Simion, "The War Between Men and Women", Xlibris, 2009. Pg 20. Bold emphasize by me.

5. Philip Graham Ryken, "The Heart of the Cross". Crossway, a publishing ministry of Good News Publishers, Wheaton, 2005. Pg 87.

6. Peter J. Gentry, "The Meaning of 'Holy' in the Old Testament," Bibliotheca Sacra 170 (2013): 417.

7. John Piper, "God Loves the Sinner, But Hates the Sin?", July 30, 2013.

8. Jeff A. Benner, The Ancient Hebrew Lexicon of the Bible, Virtual bookworm, 2005.

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10. "God Hates the Sin and the Sinner - Tim Conway", YouTube, Sep 18, 2018.

11. Does God Hate People? WyattGraham.com, April 18, 2020.

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15. Mitchell Dahood S.J., Psalms I: 1-50: Introduction, Translation, and Notes, vol. 16, Anchor Yale Bible (New Haven; London: Yale University Press, 2008), 31.

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20. https://cityofdavid.org.il/kidron-then-and-now/

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22. Fudge, The Fire That Consumes, 161-162.

23. F. W. Beare, The Gospel According to Matthew: Translation, Introduction, and Commentary (Hendrickson, 1987). p. 152.

24. In Jewish tradition, it is customary for a child to start religious education (Cheder) at the age of five. If a boy showed aptitude and interest in further religious studies, he would seek a rabbi for discipleship, emulating the rabbi's life until the age of 30. At this point, he could begin to mentor his own disciples. Typically, a young man would commence his discipleship with a rabbi between the ages of 13 and 15.

25. Matthew 5:22, 29, 30; 10:28; 18:8-9; 23:15, 33; Mark 9:43-47; Luke 12:5; James 3:6.

26. N.T. Wright, Surprised by Hope: Rethinking Heaven, the Resurrection, and the Mission of the Church. HarperOne, 2008. Pg. 176.

27. "Chronology of the War According to Josephus: Part 7, The Fall of Jerusalem."

28. E.g., the Aramaic Bible in Plain English.

29. E.g., the Contemporary English Version .

30. E.g., the Good News Translation.

31. https://www.tentmaker.org/Biblematters/fear.htm